Shadows cast

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37483363.

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Mature

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by Jematron

Summary

Reeling from the shocking turn of events, the rebels now must plan their survival.

Catra has to adjust her plans to accommodate a shocking revelation!

And what will Adora do?

Notes

I WILL be adjusting the chapter count soon, fear not. Not gonna leave y'all hanging. This one is a turning point in the arc, in their reconnection.

Should be FUN!

Also: ART! Credtis at the end!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1



Angella ran a slender hand across her face and gave a resigned glare towards the holograms floating in front of her. She leaned on the holo-table in the command-center and tried to push away the feeling of fear that coiled around her gut. Beside her Juliet droned on about the necessary shift changes and adjustments schedules. The base commander waved a hand dismissively and straightened, "Not useful, Juliet. Give me the…highlights. Our *actual* problems."

The head of security sighed and tapped on her datapad. The hologram before them adjusted to expand beyond just the image of the base and the wreckage of the *Sea Gate* . It show a larger expanse of the belt, which was now dotted with red markers, "The Imperials have begun aggressively probing the belt extremities. Their command vessel is still on station at the combat zone - likely salvaging and undertaking rescue operations. However, we're not completely sure as to their next move. We've lost our main capital ship."

"Not really *ours* , now, was it?" muttered Angella. She shook her head, "Captain Mermista?"

"In the medbay , refusing treatment. She has, um…demanded access to a combat vehicle as she wants to go out there to get some '*payback'* as I understand it. Doctor Moon has tried sedating her but decided against it."

"And our fighter wings? The mercenaries?"

"Heavy casualties. Huntara has the survivors running a patrol right now, keeping the probes confused so they can't ID us as easily. But it looks like we lost Lieutenant Hawk, plus at least seven other pilots."

"Any *good* news?"

"Well, the enemy appears to have suffered the full loss of at least two frigates, along with substantial ablative damage to their command ship. A Third frigate was disabled I believe, with a fourth sustaining major damage from the *Sea Gate*."

Angella's brow furrowed. She had seen a summary already, along with a grainy gun-cam video of the impact. A Horde frigate that acted more like a missile, "And we know the cause, Adora?"

Juliet's jaw set, "*Apparently*. Though I am unwilling to completely assign credit. It could likely have been a navigation error."

A commotion at the door drew their attention. Bow and Glimmer entered, looking haggard as they pushed past a gathering crowd. The doors hissed shut, leaving the shouts and queries of base personnel beyond. The pair strode to the display and looked between the two leaders. Glimmer folded her arms and arched an eyebrow, "So?"

Angella met her daughter's gaze and arched an eyebrow. She stood up and folded her own arms, "It is not exactly brilliant. Why aren't

you sorting out the triage?"

Glimmer snorted, "That's *done*. And I don't think the crews need me micromanaging them about supply reclamation. We need to know next steps, mo- *commander.* The crew, the civilians, everyone's restless. They want to know if the Horde are going to attack."

Angella sighed and massaged the bridge of her nose, "It's... well, we're in a bind, Glimmer. We have near to no offensive capability, especially since Adora *lost*"...

"The Adora who is currently in a fucking *coma*, you mean? The Adora who flew a fucking FRIGATE into another one and maybe *saved* the *Sea Gate*? The Adora who has basically single-handedly nailed most threats from the system?" Glimmer snarled.

"Except the most deadly one," sniffed Juliet.

"Oh shut *up*," the three women force as that had come from *Bow*. His stare was hard, "We get it, you don't like her, don't *trust* her. But you want her to do *everything*? When was the last time YOU took a combat flight out? Faced down an enemy vessel or squad, hmm?" he planted his hands on the holo table, "We have dead crew in corridors, and that wreck is pushing out so much radiation that it *will* have left a trail. So, it's not a matter of if the Horde find us, it's *when*. So, what do *we* tell the people out there? What is the *plan*?

Juliet's mouth gaped and she looked ready to rally a riposte, but shut her mouth as Angella turned to her, "The young man has a point. And so far I have been *reacting* ," the woman seemed to deflate a little, her arms dropping to her sides. She looked over to the command room door, then back at Glimmer and Bow. When she spoke, her voice was soft, "A..a coma?"

Glimmer nodded and swallowed, "W ell, Casta..she had to up the pain meds, knock her out. Seems that, well..we never did get a decent med scan of her. She always refused, hated going to the med bay. Heck, she screamed when I got her in there.." the young woman swallowed, "By the stars mom..h..er..h..er whole body it' s *grafted* with machinery. Nanites, enhancers. Grafted directly to her nervous system. ANd..it' s *eating* her."

The older women's eyes paled. Juliet frowned, "Horde tech, it' s a threat, we'…"

Angella glared at her, "Be quiet, let her *finish* ," then looked back at Glimmer. Her daughter nodded.

"Um, so..Casta managed to do a deep scan and..it' s like it's missing a part, or some sort of failsafe feature. Something to moderate the implants. Like a starship FTL drive without a navicom - it's all over the place and doesnt know to switch *off* . She's in combat mode."

They lapsed into silence and Juliet spoke up, her voice suddenly quiet, "That's... that's why she didn't want to fight?"

Bow huffed, "Maybe. But... she killed a *lot* of people on that frigate. I know that much. And how many others. *You* didn't see her in the bar after she'd been out doing us another *favour* . But... I think she hates it. She had to do it to get out."

Glimmer interjected, "Casta has a workaround. SOmething to stabilise her, temporarily."

"Is... that a priority?" asked Angella, cautiously . She didn't sound dismissive, just genuinely curious.

"If we want to get her ship back, or at least stop the Imperials making use of it, we will need her," sighed Bow , "It sounds like we're using her, *again* , but I know she'd want *Swift Wind* back as well."

They regarded the expanded map. Angella narrowed her eyes, "If… if they can track the *Sea Gate* , then why haven't they attacked?"

"Oh that's easy darlings. They aren't *stupid* ," a new voice intruded and Glimmer snorted with a complete *lack* of surprise as DT pushed themselves from their leaning position nearby. The tailor had clearly been eavesdropping. Angella gave them a tired and wan smile.

"DT . Any updates from your whisper network?"

"W ell..not really . But your original point? Those frigates and drone patrols - Huntara isn't keeping them back - they'll be using the sensor footage to gauge your actual combat strength. Once they see that there's only a few craft doing the same patrols, they'll know what they're up against. And second..they're refitting and resupplying. The enemy commander, well..going by their track record, they are *good* at strategic planning. My bet? They'll consolidate, cut of f escape routes, keep that beast of a capital ship at range and just bomb the heck outta here when they establish our defences are *squat* ," they studied their fingernails for a moment, "Almost makes me want to defect. *Again* ."

Bow tsked, "But then who would you talk to about the latest fashion faux pas?"

"Hmmm, man raises a goooooood point. But, just saying, this place is a whole heap of juicy target. Standard Imperial doctrine is *usually* swarm and overwhelm, but this Commander is being *sneaky* . She trapped golden girl, but that's *weird* as well."

The group frowned, "How so?"

"She was being shipped of f. Away. But..not under heavy guard. With a Praetorian, a fugitive one, she should've been locked in a steel box, gassed, towed *behind* a ship, with another three ships training guns on her. But I bet she hasn't got her suit. And..that

these idiots didn't *know* she was a Praetorian," DT's sharp teeth flashed in the light of the command centre, "Which means...we may have something that *makes* them pause."

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a glance, confused, "So...what? She's scary but she's ONE person. And it feels...wrong."

DT waved a hand, "Girl, she is a *soldier*. And she wants her ship, you said that yourself. Now, what *I'm* saying is that they were either shipping her out to be interrogated. But that makes no sense - they could do that here, if they thought she was important. Especially as she has that super ship. But if they knew she was a Praetorian, then that was inadequate security to move her. So, because I am an incredibly clever person and tailor *extraordinaire,* I have divined there is a connection somewhere here. Someone wanted her… away. So, that means the Commander of the enemy forces *knows* Adora dearest somehow, hmmm?"

The group exchanged confused glances. Some of the command staff also looked perplexed. Bow coughed, "That's a...leap."

"Maybe, but it's an avenue. Also, Adora probably has her *own* plan. She's a super soldier skilled at infiltration, assassination and guerilla campaigns - that's their whole *deal*. One person combat asymmetrical forces, intended to destabilise whole regions," DT shrugged and looked uncomfortable, "She brought us a prisoner… but *not* the commander of the Frigate. That I'm still trying to work out, sweeties. He's a low level crewman, a helmsman. He offers no substantial intelligence, of that I'm sure. So...why? Adora has a

plan. And..if..my whispers are to be believed, the enemy *was* on the lookout for a Praetorian."

"Ok this is..this..is getting insanely complex," huf fed Glimmer.

"I know! W elcome to my world, darling. L ovely isn't it? L ike a soap opera on the gal-net! DRAMA! SUSPENSE!" DT flourished then smirked, "Anyway , no interruptions from the peanut gallery, I am *talking* , babe. So, we have an enemy force that j ust got absolutely sideswiped by a Praetorian they knew was in system..b ut believed was allied to them..b ut likely working at cross purposes. Because if there was a Praetorian, why *wouldn't* it have made contact to co-opt their forces for whatever they needed? Maybe that' s why they were being cautious to start with. Either way, now they've been surprised, they DEFINITELY won't want to rush in. Especially if this commander has a connection to our sweet little blonde killing machine."

Angella rolled her eyes, "T enuous at best, to base a strategy on this supposition."

"Maybe darling, but you didn't listen to me before and, well, we nearly ended up spaced by that little ball of irritable resentment and trust issues!"

Juliet growled at that but turned her head a way with a muttered, "...Fair"…

"SO! We can bet they will likely be considering their options a DT more carefully. They dont know if Adora has any further tricks up her sleeve. She doesnt know how well integrated we are with her. They just knew she had a funky ship. So, they will *most likely* do a slow advance, gauge strengths, then either move to utterly blow us to pieces to be sure. Or go for an invasion to ensure Adora and we are completely, beyond doubt, neutralised."

"That seems extreme," Bow frowned, "A full invasion of a station that's a lot. Even with our defences in a poor state. They'd do that"...

"Over a rogue Praetorian? Yes. Yes they would. Normal protocol involves sending FIVE other Praetorians to neutralise any high level compromised unit. so what do you think they'd send for a rogue *Praetorian*. They NEVER go rogue. Never," DT huf fed and looked away, a cloud of something like guilt on their face, "Well. I can bet that the commander *won't* be calling for help yet."

Angella flung her hands up, "So, what, we SHOUDNT bank on another five death troopers just manifesting in our base to slaughter us in our beds?" her voice was shrill, her accent mor clipped. Everyone winced and DT grimaced.

"No. BEcause, like I said. there's a connection, darling. This commander wanted Adora out of the way. but not *dead*. Easier to space a corpse, surely? If she wanted intel, they'd have kept her. They wanted her gone, they'd have just shoved her in an airlock. But no, they devoted a whole frigate en route to the edge of the system. They wanted her gone, free. Not handed over to mil-int."

The head of security frowned, "You know this how?"

"Oh I took five minutes to chat to our little blonde soldier boy in the brig. He's...mostly conscious. And very confused, the poor sweet thing. But look at how out of routine such a task is for the Horde - a frigate with no handover orders? We'd have intercepted those, I can be sure of that. He just confirmed it."

The group shook their heads and Glimmer puffed up, "So...what, then? We use Adora as some sort of human shield?"

DT shrugged, "No, but...maybe we wake up blondie and see what her wondrous master plan is, hmmm? All I'm saying is that we may have more time than, yknow, expected. Either way," DT huffed, "I recommend we all get the heck outta here."

Angella glowered, "Abandon Brig-"

"Hell *yes*," DT mocked, "Darling, this has been a fabulous little hideaway, but we need to *relocate*. The neighbours are simply *dreadful*. And they will come knocking. The term target rich environment' sound good to you, hmmm?"

Bow shook his head and looked bleak, "DT's right, we need to consider evacuation plans. We might be able to hit them, but that

Destroyer...if they do decide to just go for a killing blow, that main gun will take out any external units and...well that's life support *gone*. We're vulnerable. Even with the turrets on the foids and picket ships. We can't take a siege."

The commander and Juliet shared a glance and nodded, "We need to...explore contingencies. Worst case scenarios. You"...Angella sighed, looking torn.

Glimmer looked at the despondent faces, "I guess we need to talk to Adora then. I hate it but...she seems our main hope," she sighed, "And...hope that this commander of theirs is having second thoughts."

Bow and Glimmer turned to head for the exit leaving the somber Angella and Juliet behind them, with DT suddenly falling in step with. Bow shot the tailor a look, and the green skinned show-off shot him a enigmatic grin, "What? Miss my chance to see that cocky girl laid low? Gotta get my hits in while I can!"

Glimmer glared at him, "You know a lot about the Praetorians, DT."

The tailor looked momentarily uncomfortable then shrugged, "Doesn't hurt to say. I've been freelance for *years* darling. But I did spend a lot of time, shall we say, on retainer. And, well...no other division of the Empire eats intel and psychological analysis like the Praetorian guard. Of course is wasn't part of my role to get involved but I'm a *snoop*. Can't be helped and...well, I saw more than I ever should have. Made me a bit of a *wanted* individual. Luckily I am great at reinventing myself, hmm? And I made sure I was at least

more useful far away and alive than close to home and *dead* . For a while."

Bow cocked his head, "What did you see?"

DT's face lost it's amused look, "I saw how they *made* them"…

Catra bit down on her knuckle, eyes locked on the screen. A lump sat in her throat at she stared.

" *Oh this is an interesting part. Where the most resilient are selected. Intense psychoanalysis, pain threshold testing, recovery rates. A lot went into the decision making. Part of my compatriot's duties was, well, ferreting out suitable candidates."*

There was so much blood. The sound was muted. Catra had shrieked at Weaver to do that. She could see the word the blonde was mouthing at the camera, red smears across her neck, barely visible above above…

Catra turned and dry heaved.

“As you can see, the prolonged interrogation period lasts several weeks, to ensure mental flexibility. Contrary to expectations this is not intended to break the subject. It is actually to ensure enough resilience is established for implantation and that they cannot be compromised by external means,” Weaver’s synthesised voice seemed to be relishing the activity on screen.

“Why.why are you showing me”…

“Because, Captain, this is intelligence vital to your success,” The AI’s voice was honeyed, cloying, *“And my continued success depends on your worthless carcass of meat and neurons continuing in a functional capacity. That… vessel you captured is a gateway to both your success and my prolonged survival. This… Adora. You are directly responsible for what she has experienced; for what she has become. She is no longer the girl you remember. She is a violent, amoral killing machine and likely seeks your untimely demise.”*

Catra stared at the frozen mage on the screen. The manipulator arms, drenched in sickly green and blue light;bloodied clamps and needles;sparking electrodes. She swallowed, thickly , bile in her throat, fear tight in her gut. A memory floated up, from her conversation with Adora. T coupled with the soundless name on those lips.

That could have been *her* .

If Adora had broken. If she had just given up. She could've ended it and let Catra take her place. That was what the Imperial torturers had implied, right?

Or was that just a ruse to keep Adora focused? Either way , Adora had believed it.

Catra's stomach felt like lead. While she'd been moaning about bad assignments, Adora had, what? Been out killing people?

"But..after this, why would she even *work* for the Empire? Hell, I'd turn on you in a heartbeat."

"You mean you haven't already. Captan you're a hairs breadth away from being a privateer, with how you interpret orders. Although your methods do align with acceptable Horde promotion policy. And compliance is factored into the implants. Without the corresponding suit to moderate the internal engines, they will consume the subject due to the high energy cost. The suit is the system by which a Praetorian can more effectively control those implants. All bespoke technology sourced from… specialist locations."

Catra turned away from the image. She'd seen the files Weaver had managed to procure. Adora had been part of a new model "batch", but the only survivor of the program. She had suspicions about that but hadnt read through the full, mostly redacted, dossier . She had also only perused snippets of the transmitted video logs from the now-obliterated Frigate.

It was horrifying to say the least.

But it also raised *more* questions.

Like: If Adora was so hell bent on killing her, why *hadn't* she? She seemed more than capable? Or was there some limit? Did she want to do it a certain way? Did she have a game plan?

Or was it that she wanted her ship and having Catra alive was a requirement for that?

Catra twitched and glared up at the speaker in the corner of the room, "So you want me to kill her?"

"She will be a problem, even deprived of her ship. If she has access to a Praetorian suit, then she is a serious concern. We may have her primary vessel but it may not be her only means of conveyance. You wish to succeed, to climb the ladder and become something more than frontier patrol trash? Well, she is an obstacle to that. She is not that doe eyed friend from your cadet days. Your choices have seen to that."

"You're pretty sure she wants to kill me."

“I want to kill you, Captain. And you have done far less to me. It is the only logical outcome. I have a record of some of her hits. Clean, swift. But some… some she toyed with. I believe this is what she wants for you. I would.”

“Oh you're just really charming today , aren't you?” spat the Captain. She hunched up in her chair and brought her knees up to her chest. That, in itself, was a painful motion for the sensory memories it conjured up - late nights in the Academy after grueling training sessions.

Her thoughts were interrupted by the chime of the door alert. Hastily Catra closed down the viewscreens and managed to snarl out an *enter* .

Her XO tentatively stepped into the ready room, from the bridge, “Uh...ma'am?”

“Scorpia,” Catra scowled at her XO, “So?”

“Uh, initial sweeps done. W e've..we've manage to identify several escape pods and EVA suits from debris. Survivors and bodies are being organised in cargo hold beta. Prisoners are awaiting processing, got a few rebels in the mix at least,” she smiled weakly , “So not a complete write of f, eh, Wildcat?”

Catra unfolded from the chair and stalked towards her XO, who stumbled back. Catra glared up at her, "We lost *how* many?"

"Uh..um, at least..ninety"...

"Over NINETY crewmen. In ONE engagement, Scorpia. That looks fucking *dire* . Yeah I know the Horde has acceptable attrition rates, but numbers like that should be for DRONES. Two frigates, a third crippled, a fourth damaged. And we hit, what, ONE capital ship and winged a freighter, plus some fighter craft" she ran a clawed hand through her hair, "By the stars..at this rate, we may end up with a single escape pod and call it a VICTORY!"

Scorpia winced at the biting sarcasm, "Well, uh, we had some unforeseen..".

"No. Fucking. SHIT Scorpia. That came outta nowhere, *didn't it?* She's a fucking SUPER SODIER!" Catra hissed in frustration and spun back to her desk, then planted her palms on its surface. Scorpia took a step forwards.

"Yes, but..who could've predicted that? We took the precautions as we saw them."

"Not good enough. What next? So far We've hit a ship that is impossible, now a secret mega trooper? What next? A planetkiller disguised as a friggin' teapot or something? Black hole cannons?

These people just seem to pull magic rainbows out of their asses," she slumped against the desk.

"Maybe Entrapta can field that one?" joked Scorpia, "kinda her thing, right?"

"Right," sighed the Captain. She drummed her fingers on the desk and shook her head, "Right, game plan. Losses aren't good. Assume we've tracked that Capital ship?"

Scorpia nodded, "It's in the belt, near a large rock which seems to have a lot of conflicting EM frequencies. Reckon it's a base."

Catra nodded slowly, "Yeah the other installations out here are too small to support the traffic we've been seeing. A roid waystation… makes sense, most of the people here are miners," her voice was distracted, her face pensive. For the first time she felt *off* about what they were out here to do.

A military cruiser. To intimidate *miners.* That would have been her whole thing out here.

Weaver had said she was a Privateer. And the blasted computer wasn't entirely wrong.

She and Adora had dreamed of power, freedom, authority - the freedom away from being wrenched around by those who would do them harm. And now?

Adora had ended up a thrall to that, because of Catra. And Catra was doing that to others.

She shook herself and glared at the floor. No, she was bringing *order*. And she was keeping her crew away from the worst of it.

Ninety dead men and women, at least.

Catra shivered, then drew in a breath, "Ok, a direct assault. We need to neutralise the main bulk of the threat *but* . they may have more defences," she chewed her lip and one ear twitched in agitation, "Huh we give them too much time they dig in, fortify maybe. Orrrr evacuate and we end up having to chase them down again"…

"So, um. orders, ma'am?"

Catra's mind was filled with the visual of the Frigates, expanding in a ball of nuclear fire. Her eyes narrowed, "How about. some karma? Keep frigates on station, monitor their movements. We need to make sure they haven't got an easy out. Adora will be there, I bet. We need to capture her."

"Uh..capture?"...

Catra bared her teeth, "Y es. She knows more. She must do. A secret ship? *Please,* that didn't just happen..and if..if..we *have* her then we know she isn't just *pretending* to be dead," Catra's voice cracked a little but she bit down on it.

Scorpia blinked in surprise, Catra's gaze was firmly in the middle distance. The silence was broken by Weaver's synthetic voice, " *That would be unwise, Captain. And likely to fail."*

"Noted, W eaver," Catra practically hissed the words, "But if we can neutralise her then we can ensure she's not a threat. Capture means we can also..also"..part of her wanted to say *return her to the Horde* . Because maybe then, maybe they could be on the same side. Maybe she could fix it, make Adora not want to kill her , they could..what? Catra's fingers flexed on the table surface. She heaved a sigh, "W e need to take that base. It will be an intel hotbed: records, shipping lanes, personnel records. Disrupt that, we make this whole area easier for the Empire to enforce law within. With Adora..she is an Imperial asset and a threat. If we can't secure her without casualties then..then we need to eliminate her . For now, set course back to base, get those harassing patrols out to keep the rebels on the defensive. We need them agitated, panicked and reactive. No more surprises. I want that sector under a freakin' microscope," she pushed of f the desk, "Back to base. Repair as much as we can en route, resupply and cycle the fringe frigates into our escort. Have them RV in orbit."

"A ye aye."

"And get Entrapta raised. Wanna see if she's made headway. Any… initial finds. Plus," Catra's smirk was unpleasant, "We'll need her expertise for that bit of payback."

Scorpia noted the expression and nodded slowly, "Of course Captain. Will you be heading to the bridge?"

"No. I think I need to check in on the casualties. Be seen. And then," she studied her claws, "Maybe have a quick chat with our guests. After all," her eyes narrowed, "We wouldn't want to get caught off guard *again*."

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

A survivor is revealed!

What are Adora's plans for Kyle?

And what does the revelation of Entrapta's discovery mean for the Rebels and... the Empire?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bright lights and a pounding headache - frankly, that was a pretty good start to the day, by most measures. Of course this wasn't the *good* kind of splitting headache that followed on from a bacchanal of glorious frivolity and grand exploration. Or even just running like a loon from whatever ire had been generated.

"You're awake," came a gruff but clearly feminine voice from off to one side.

"It would *appear* so." The words came out hoarse, pained.

"Name?" The voice was curt, but had an edge to it.

"Oh we don't do that name, rank, serial number and all that! Sebastian Hawk and that's *all* you're getting from me."

Seahawk groaned and tried to sit up, but the *clink* of metal restraints put paid to that. He managed to crack his eyes open against the glare and tried to take stock: Spartan, bare surroundings, utilitarian settings, the scent of antiseptic and the faint coppery tang of blood. A medical bay. An *Imperial* medical bay.

"Oh *bugger*," he groaned, before slumping back against the frankly *insulting* excuse for a pillow. He managed to turn his head to regard his would-be interrogator and realised she was a fellow patient. However, she wasn't shackled to a bed and, while he was in what could be charitably be called a *gown*, she had the dressed down uniform of a soldier: olive shirt and grey trousers. Her face looked drawn, her dark skin showing signs of grey. Her hair, set in cornrows, looked frayed. She was watching him with a strange expression, "Yes?" he offered.

She blinked and sighed, then drew her knees up to her chest, "You're one of the, uh... rebels?"

"Well, actually I'm more of a *pirate*. Privateer? Gentleman adventurer? I find labels so *passe*!" he waved a hand, or tried to. It came out as more a shackled flail, but his practiced smile showed he was attempting levity, "We weren't even rebelling. Not really. Just… living, yknow? Then you lot come clomping in with your size nine jackboots and, well!"

"You could've just..." the woman shrugged and sighed, her eyes focusing off in the middle distance, "We should never have fired on

her,"she whispered.

Hawk frowned, "Ok I'm a little lost. My soulmate, light of my life Mer… *ahem* .well, she would say that' s par for the course, *however* , I do find myself somewhat.confused."

"Huh"the woman looked back at him. She was clearly disorientated.

"First..Y ou are?"he splayed one shackled hand in a very limited gesture of *you* .

"Oh uh..Leutenant Bnnie."she drifted of f, a frown on her face.

"No last name, ok, I suppose that' s OpSec or whatever it is you military yahoos do. Sooooo..Where am I?"

"Medbay ,"grunted the woman. She glanced at him and huf fed, "On the *Enduring Advance* ."

"Hmm, sounds *fancy* . No room service though. I am a little insulted at the lack of guards."

Bnnie shrugged, "They're watching you. Not long before you get hauled to interrogation like your *friends* ,"she was clearly trying for

malice, but there was no energy there. Hawk sighed.

"Honestly , Im just surprised to be here. Blaze of glory and all that."

The Horde soldier turned a bit more to stare at him, "Whaddya mean?"

"W ell, it was me, alone, in my trusty shuttle, the Dragon's Daughter… um.six.Seven? Anyway! Just me, my wits and skill against the Imperial fleet!" he tried to shake his fist, but just rattled it against his restraints, "One man, against the odds, to save his damsel in distress."

Lonnie snorted, but tried to stifle it, "Y ou got arrested for smugglin' right?"

"NO! I bombed their Destroyer! W ell..your destroyer I suppose," he grinned, "Not bad, if I do say so myself. I mean, could've been better if the darn thing had, well, caught *fire* or something. Gone *kaboom* ."

Her face twisted, "And left all the crew for dead?"

He met her gaze, but didn't shy away from it, "Like the crew on the ship the Destroyer was trying to blow out of the sky? The crippled ship?"

Bonnie shifted, "A *warship*, right? That's…"

"And isn't this a warship, hmm?" Hawk leaned back and gave a shrug, "Can't play the victim. Pick a fight, get bruised. I mean *I hate* getting bruised. This face? It's a travesty! But…well, I was a coward for a long time. Sometimes you have to knuckle up, y'know?"

They lapsed into silence for a moment before Bonnie spoke again, "Why aint you freakin' out?"

Hawk frowned and turned his head, "I mean, I'm handcuffed to a bed, there's a lovely lady next to me, the lighting is…not quite right. Surely I should be thanking my creators?" He grinned at her glare, then shrugged, "I nearly died. Maybe I am dead and this is a fever dream. What matters is that…is that *she* is safe. And the survivors are safe. That's all that matters. I can…I can weather the rest."

He swallowed and licked his lips, his bravado not quite convincing. Bonnie sighed, then swung her legs from her bed and shuffled to a nearby shelf. She unhooked a reusable water canteen and filled it at the dispenser, then shuffled over to his bedside and offered the canteen. Hawk grinned and wiggled his hands. Bonnie rolled her eyes and pressed the canteen to his lips, then tilted it gently, "Better?"

"*Much*. My thanks, fair maid."

"Anyone tell you you're slick?"

"It's one of my best *and* worst qualities, apparently," Bonnie sat back on her bed and stared at him for a moment. She had a clouded expression on her face and seemed conflicted.

"So, um," Bonnie trailed off and Hawk adjusted his shoulders. He felt sore and the headache was only abating slightly. But it was likely this was the best he'd feel for a while. He waited and just stared at the ceiling. Silence lapsed before Bonnie spoke up again, "So if... if you guys capture us, whaddya do with them?"

Hawk turned his head to her and arched an eyebrow, "Never really happened."

She twitched at that, "You mean you"...

That got a guffaw from Hawk, but he winced at the pain in his ribs, which reduced the laugh to a wheeze, "No... no, I mean... we do hit and run? We're *civilians*. What would we do with prisoners? We barely have *cells*. No, as my darling says, *better to let them go, so we can rob them again!"*

Bonnie stifled a snort at that, "Way generous of you."

Hawk managed an awkward shrug, "Now , unless my ears deceive me, that was a *loaded* question. One doesn't become a seasoned adventurer without spotting these things y'know!"

That got a frown from the black girl. She shuffled her feet and tugged at the collar of her shirt before she crossed her arms, "There it…" she hissed out a breath, then leveled a glare at him, "Y our pet *monster* killed my crew and kidnapped my friend."

He stared at her, nonplussed, until realisation dawned, "Ohhhhhh. You mean *Adora* !"

Bonnie blinked at his cheerful face and entirely unbothered air , "Y eah. Tall, blonde and *crazy* ."

"W ell, I don't know her all that well, aside from that one time where she launched dear Huntara across the bar. Or, well, that incident with the dock workers. Orrr that time when…actually , now I think on it, I can see why you'd consider her a bit *much* ."

"A bit *much* ?" drawled Bonnie, "Seriously?" she leaned forwards and whispered, "She *took* my…a friend. Just straight up kidnapped him."

Hawk looked at her and his eyes narrowed, "And you want to know where?"

Bonnie chewed her lip and shrugged, "I mean..it..couldn't hurt."

Hawk laughed, a short bark, "Dim though I may appear , I was not born yesterday. You're doing a good 'good enforcer'. I'm sure the devilish *bad* cop will be along shortly, hmm? Bit low of your sort to stage a patient and q iz a chap who' s just woken up from near decompression! Devilishly unfair!"

He winced as he adjusted himself and Bonnie scowled at him, "I am *not* a plant."

Hawk nodded to the cameras, "Buuuut I doubt they just left you in here with minimal security for a *bad* reason."

Bonnie just scof fed at that, "You're cuf fed to a bed. Try anything and..they'll be here."

"Exactly . So, they're probably just waiting for me to spill my secrets to a sympathetic ear."

"No..well..that' s their gameplan, fine," Hawk watched Bonnie as she spoke. She had her hands clasped together now and she leaned forwards to whisper, "I just..I..can guess where she took him. W e *know* , or will know soon enough. The Commander's no fool. But..is he..will he be safe? She..she was a *demon* ."

She met Hawk's eyes, but looked away as he stared at her. After a moment, he let out a deep breath and slumped against the pillow, "Well...If she took him where I *think* she might have then likely he will be being looked after and cared for. We...or rather the *system government,* dont condone mistreatment of prisoners - it triggers repercussions. We start abusing prisoners, then it all rather goes a bit silly, doesnt it? T it, tat, all that. So...he's probably fine." He went for reassuring. It was always useful to have *somebody* in your corner and Hawk felt he'd probably need all the help he could garner .

Bonnie stared at him and shifted slightly , "Probably?"

He winced, "Wellllll, Adora is a bit unpredictable. BUT she has never hurt someone who didnt *start* it. And I've never seen her kick someone who couldnt fight back. Dont think it's in her nature."

"So...where...where would he be?" Bonnie whispered. Hawk sighed.

"That...I cant say . I could guess, buuuut I wont be able to tell you. Sorry." He made another half shrug.

"But why'd she *take* him?" muttered Bonnie to herself, "Why not… me?"

"That..well that" Hawk was interrupted as the medbay door slid open. A feline form in a Captain's uniform stalked in, a smirk on her face, flanked by a pair of helmeted guards. She regarded Hawk for a moment before speaking.

"Good question, right? Bonnie, nice try but I dont think he' s receptive."

The injured soldier looked abashed, but more towards Hawk. He shrugged at her and managed to lift his head up enough to regard the new arrival, "Oh dont blame her . Hardly going to trust anyone in my predicament, now am I?"

"Fair point," the cat-woman shrugged and regarded him, "Captain Catra. Commander of all Horde forces in the sector."

"Charmed and I suppose..honoured? I'd shake your hand but, well, you havent left me much choice."

"Wow. She wasnt wrong you are slick."

Hawk glanced up at the camera in the corner of the room and nodded, his suspicions confirmed. Clearly Bonnie wasnt learning enough from him, "When you have one gift in life, exploit it, that' s what dear old mama said, right before she stole my father's shuttle and high-tailed it off world. Ahhh. Good times," Hawk leaned back, "Though, if youre taking feedback, the catering here is *abysmal* .

Bonnie did her best with the water but I could *murder* a glass of Salinean rum right now."

Catra stared at him, then snorted, "Well I'll be sure to pass that along to the Penitentiary board and Indentured worker compliance council."

"Would you? So kind!" Hawk managed. In truth he was a *tad* nervous.

"Bonnie, doc give you a clean bill of health?" The Captain's attention was momentarily distracted. Bonnie nodded, "Good. Report to Commander Scorpia for assignment and a further debrief."

The soldier saluted, then shot Hawk a side glance, before she sidled out of the room. Catra watched her go, then moved to check the status readout next to Hawk's bed. She huffed then gestured to the two guards with her. They moved forwards and uncuffed the man, then hauled him to his feet. He managed a bit of bravado, "Is this the part where I go into the airlock, or do I get a bit of Horde speciality massage to my kidneys first?"

Catra paused at the door and regarded him, "We aren't *savages*."

"Oh? I mean the whole attacking civilians and extorting them for money and supplies had me a bit confused."

"Says the pirate," deadpanned Catra.

"Ehhh *privateer*. Your vessels are legitimate military targets. They can fight back," he smiled, "Bit more of a challenge, no?"

Catra grunted then turned, Hawk shuffling behind her in the grip of the guards. They moved through the ship until they reached the brig, and within it, a small interrogation room. Hawk was manhandled into a metal chair and cuffed in. Catra watched, then pulled another chair over, letting its legs scrape along the steel floor. She hopped onto it and squatted down to regard Hawk, her head tilting one way then the other as she stared at him.

He stared back, nerves fraying a little as he met her mismatched gaze - one amber eye, one blue. She looked at him like he was a bug, dispassionate, almost bored. She exhaled out of her nose then settled back on her haunches, "My AI thinks we should filet you, stitch you up, filet you *again*, then start asking questions," Hawk couldn't hide the swallow, "I said we should at least give you a *chance* before destroying that fragile excuse for a brain you have in there."

"And you ah said you weren't barbarians."

"Oh nothing barbaric about it. All very fixable. And avoidable. Cause and effect, yknow. Law and order," Catra smiled, but it seemed hollow. Almost sad. Hawk stared at her then tilted his own head.

"Much experience with it?"

Catra blinked, "Interrogation? Of course. But I'm asking the questions, pretty boy."

"I mean... holding the scalpel. Not saying I'm not *thrilled* you're taking a personal interest but... I imagine you'll delegate the actual slicing, right? But before we get there, I suppose no harm asking questions, right? I'm afraid I won't be telling you where our base is."

Catra waved a hand, "Eh, not an issue. We know where it is. Your busted Capital ship was leaking so much radiation it's like a beacon. If it blows up it'll just make an easy job easier. Nah, I'm more concerned about the preservation of *life*. You seem a clever sort, stupid mustache aside. We can end all this, minimise the bloodshed, minimise the number of people who need to be made an example of."

Hawk actually glared at her and Catra laughed. He shook his head, "Executions, really?"

"Psh, no. Waste of time and just makes *martyrs*. No, we ship some people off to the mines, the indentured farms. Pay off their debt to society. Cleaner, keeps those left behind a bit more in line," she drummed her claws on her knee, "I'm just asking for details on capability, defences, troop numbers. Where I *shouldn't* aim my siege weapons, yknow. Be a shame if some hab block on whatever station is there got hit because we just thought it was a battery."

Hawk looked at the woman in front of him and breathed out, "They will stop you. My love will stop you. She will burn everything to free me and"…

"Eh, they probably think you're K.A. Ran with their tail between their legs."

"Good. Time to regroup," Hawk jutted his chin out. Catra shrugged, looking bored.

"Maybe. Im oh so scared of that flying piece of scaf folding."

"And Adora will"…

The name made Catra's whole demeanour shift. She glared at Hawk, "Oh yeah. Do tell. What will your precious little pet monster do? We have her ship. She's gonna do *what* ? One busted Horde fighter against *us* . I dont think so."

Hawk stared, "Ah, well. I imagine shell" he winced, "Are you… ok?"

Catra blinked and growled, "What does that mean?"

I mean you seem…antsy?"

That caused a twitch in Catra's eye. She inhaled, then pulled her cap off to smooth her hair down. With a huff, she exhaled and managed a thin smile, "*Excuse me*, but your little freak murdered a good portion of my men. A little ungrateful, considering I was helping her leave the system," her smile grew as she clocked Hawk's expression, "Oh, didn't know that part? We were flying her outta here. All pally pally. But then she decided to go mad and murdered our crew. And now she's with *your* people. Hardly loyal of her, y'know? Gave us her ship, we give her a ride and how does she repay us? Death. Kidnapping."

Hawk blinked in confusion, "No, she's…she's a miner. A decent ship, she…what? How? I mean she fights, yes, get's angry but… you're pulling my leg."

Catra waved to one of the guards, who flicked on a wall monitor. Scenes of Adora butchering her way through the Frigate she'd been on flashed onto the screen. The feline tilted her head, "There's war, then there's double crossing people. She took one of mine. Murdered everyone else. Spared Bonnie. No idea why. Any ideas?"

Hawk blinked again, confused by this line of questioning. He'd expected fists or shouting about ship numbers, "What are you asking?"

"Fairly simple. Why'd she take my people?"

"Actionable intelligence? I don't know!"

"Bonnie was the ranking officer. She has access. Had access. Had more up to date info. Why leave her?"

"You're asking me? I'm a PILOT."

"You know her," Catra shrugged, then flicked to gun-cam footage from a drone fighter. It showed blocky images of Seahawk's run on the Destroyer, "Quite impressive. Dumb, but impressive. What did you hope to achieve?"

"I'd think that was obvious," scoffed the pirate.

"Yeah, I guess," Catra looked at the monitor, "You must care an awful lot about the people on that ship... or maybe just *someone*."

That hit. Hawk was addled, despite his bravado. Oxygen deprivation, dehydration and disorientation weren't helping, I won't"…

Catra looked back at him and sighed sadly, "Look. I was targeting a *legitimate* military threat. I reckon that's been neutralised, barring some small combat vessel, y'know?" she nodded and Hawk

responded, then stopped his own head nod. Catra smiled, but kindly, "HEy , I get loyalty. I have to be a bit of a hardass because, yknow , you are an enemy combatant. You did try to kill the crew on this ship. Stop them getting back to their families, yknow? It' s all so grey, I *get* that. I do."

She slid down and sat properly in her chair. Hawk swallowed and tried to lean back, but his restraints just clicked. Catra regarded them and winced, then waved a guard over to remove them. They unclasped and Hawk massaged his wrists, "I know what you're trying to do."

"Y eah, Im trying to get you onside. Oh I dont expect you to sign up and start singing the March. Nah, I dont *want* to hurt you. I want this *solved* soon as, so we can allllll go back to normal. Your people can keep digging their rocks. My people can keep the peace. You pirates can find employment elsewhere. Right now it' s just a back and forth, no winners. Next attack, itll get messy . People will be caught in the crossfire. I *can't* pull punches. And if I dont know where soft targets are versus military ones people will die."

Hawk watched as the woman leaned forwards to rest her forearms on her knees. He winced and looked away, "I cannot betray and I dont know the base layout. I youll have to." he closed his eyes, "I cant."

Catra sighed and splayed her hands, "Think about it. W ell get you some food, you can have a sleep. If we wanted deaths, we'd have left you floating out there. Like I said, we know *where* the base is. I just need to make this as smooth as possible. Y ou could save lives

Sebastian . You were being a hero before, misguided maybe. Reckless. Think about it. If your friends are hiding behind civilians, who's the bad guy? Give us details, we can ensure they get out. W e make it a *fair* fight. Think about it."

She pushed off the chair and gestured for the guards to open the door. The soldiers led Hawk, more gently this time, to one of the cells. He slumped into it then looked up, face grave, "I wont betray them."

"Maybe not. But at least give me an idea that my soldier is safe."

"I"…

"A communication line will do," Catra shrugged, "Just so we can validate. I dont want to just spam signals at them."

Hawk sagged, "Let me think."

"Good man," Catra smiled and turned away , "Get him some food and replacement coveralls. We arent *monsters* ."

Hawk shook his head, frowning, as the door to the brig hissed shut.

Catra exhaled as she entered the bridge. She noted Bonnie was at the helm duty station, with Rogelio nearby. The reptile kept glancing at her, curious and nervy. No wonder - he *mattered* to them both. The feline caught Scorpia's eye and gestured for her to follow her to the ready room.

As the door hissed shut behind the Scorponi Commander Catra settled herself into the seat behind her desk. She regarded Scorpia and then glanced up at the ceiling, "So, W eaver?"

" *I still feel you are being soft, Captain."*

"Uncertainty . He was *expecting* a fight, a beating, pain. He was ready for it. He'd take a while to break and no guarantee we'd get anything useful," she shrugged, "Not that we need much. It' s just an avenue in case he has *more* we can use. Can never hurt to know more."

Scorpia shifted, "Fair assessment. The other captives weren't much help. Low level crew . SOme spoke about the station buuuut they weren't command crew . No co-ordinates data, nothing beyond some basic info about its bar," the woman shrugged.

Catra shook her head, "Nah. he could be a useful psy-ops tool. Get a vid-com message to their crews, get some uncertainty going. That

Adora comment had him for a loop,” she smiled, but it was an ugly expression. It looked forced. Scorpia kept her mouth shut however - Catra was a bit on edge about the whole *Adora* situation.

“So, uh. Bonnie is. she seems focused.”

The Captain’s head snapped up, “About that. Keep an eye.”

“Ma’am?”

“The Captain is, much as it pains me to say this, correct. The Lieutenant is a weak link. She has a vulnerability . The Praetorian will look to exploit this.”

“So. we take her of f active duty then?” Scorpia asked.

“No, you simpleton. That will give her free time to stew. Lock her in the brig, we get questions. Her quarters? The same. Probability indicates she would seek an exit and a means to rescue her crewmate.”

“But. we’re doing that, right?” Scorpia frowned, “She knows we’re gonna do that, why would she risk things?”..

Catra shook her head and chuckled, "Because she's stressed and nearly died. We need her on task. Not idle. Just keep an eye on her. *Adora* took Kyle for a reason. He's a low level ensign, he knows *nothing*. Which means she's either stupid or she wants to use him for something."

"Sounds uh...a bit paranoid. How?"

"Identity key, torturing him for trivial information, blackmail… depends on the longer term. Also we must consider the possibility he will be returned as a sleeper agent. It may be preferable to just eliminate him. The Lieutenant should not be privy to this, of course," purred Weaver.

Catra looked uncomfortable but gave a half shrug. Scorpia stared at her, then looked at the ceiling speaker incredulously, "You *agree*, ma'am?"

"We must consider *all* our options. You may not *get* this *Scorpia,* but Adora is a freakin' *Praetorian*. She killed a whole CREW. She *somehow* overrode Weaver's proxy without breaking a *sweat*. So, yeah, I'm gonna be cautious as *hell* until she's dead."

That last word came out as a near squeak and Catra seemed to stiffen for a moment. She swallowed and looked away. Scorpia wasn't sure what the deal was, aside from *some* prior connection between the two - training, perhaps? But the precise details remained vague to her. Catra hadn't shared the detailed videos

about Adora, nor much beyond her more recent performance files. Those were chilling reading, true enough.

"Duly noted, ma'am. Ill uh..Ill keep Bonnie focused. Anything *else*?" Scorpia tried to keep the bite from her words - she wasnt naturally harsh, despite her position, but this was unexpected, considering how she, Catra and Entrapta had been running things. The change in her commander was disconcerting.

"Yeah, wanted an update from Entrapta," Catra leaned forwards and keyed in a code to her desk console. There was a chime, then a 3d holo of Entrapta materialised above the desk.

"CATRA! Oh goodness your timing is amazing! The quantum waveform from the vessel must be influencing local events and…"

"Woa woa," Catra held up her hands, "Simmer down, Trap. Vessel is secure?"

"What? OH, yes, totally. And completely impervious to entry tools, unless I want to blast it apart!"

Catra frowned, "It's invulnerable?"

“ *Not QUITE. It’ s interesting, it shares a lot of similarities to the shield harmonics used by the Velvet Glove… you know, Imperial Headquarters? And the energy waveform is… familiar from something else.”*

“I know the station, Entrapta,” sighed Catra. Her brow furrowed, “Wait, what?”

“ *Yes it’s fascinating - the harmonics are EXACTLY similar. I mean, I really SHOULDN’T know that, but when you find detailed blueprints on a secure node, it’s rude NOT to read them. What’s the point of that unless you WANT them read? I mean, really . Anyway, the ship is powered down and seems to be in a sort of… stasis? So there’s nothing else for the shield to do but be a REALLY STRONG SHIELD. No wonder we could barely hit her . We can move the ship, but breaching it will be problematic… for the moment! I’m working on some counters right now.”*

Catra rubbed her temple, “So, it’ s a bust. crap, Hordak’ s gonna just *take* it isn’t he,” she sighed.

“A bust? Why would you say that?”

“We’ve got a fancy paperweight, Entrapta. An invulnerable one but…”

“ *Hmmm, well I don’t know why you think it’s not useful. I’ve got TONS of data we can use.”*

Catra paused and frowned, "Huh?"

"YES! Those harmonics… the scans I've taken, imaging… well, I have a good idea of the shape of the generator inside, along with fuel source, and how we can maybe emulate some of it…"

Catra stared at the hologram, "Go on."

"Of course, how it's interfacing to a piece of, well… rather junky technology is confusing. I'm actually moderately impressed, though it feels like a waste for such advanced technology to be powering the equivalent of a cargo loader. This thing could be scaled up to run a frigate or or or even a Destroyer. A battleship! IMAGINE!"

"Yeah," breathed Catra, "I imagine"…

Scorpia frowned at the look on her friend's face, "Ma'am?"

Catra waved a hand, her focus on Entrapta, "So you think you can… maybe replicate some of the functionality?"

"*Definitely. We have a fabrication unit here after all, left by the survey team. I've had it fabbing more fabber units so we can start*

replacing ordinance and equipment buuuut I can retool it to something else. What are you thinking?"

The Captain chuckled, "Well that thing's a hard to crack paperweight..but if we can show similar results.. Well now."

"I can't do a standalone generator - I'd need to actually see it. But I can… replicate the output. It's going to be fuel intensive buuuuut I think I can run a small scale prototype at least."

"Oh yeah, that..that's good," Catra chuckled, "Good news, excellent stuff Entrapta. Share the details with Weaver, keep me updated.

"With… Weaver?"

"Yeah, she's still shackled. But..yeah share the broad stuff. She might have an insight."

"Uh, ok."

"Also, how's your team coming on with the black box analysis?"

"Ah, um… well… we're working on it. That Adora is SCARY. Still not sure how she bypassed Weaver's ICE protocols or hijacked

command lines. She's not on file with command privileges but… not like she's even got a vocal wavelength that… huh… wave… length…"

Entrapta paused, a frown on her face. She scrubbed at her scalp, her tendril like hair wavering, before her eyes bugged out. Catra reared back at the sudden shift, "What?"

" *Wavelengths! I am so silly! Familiar energy! In sync! They're the same! I need to run tests! She spoofed SOMETHING someHOW . Praetorian overrides, hard coded in perhaps? A good counter to the Weavers, yes, that'd make sense. Have the Weavers make the troopers, but have the troopers able to override the Weavers… redundancy, countermeasures. Paranoid, yes, makes sense, but but but… hmmm. Still, to do that, well they have nanites and… but the energy needed would mean hmmm…"*

"ENTRAPT A! Focus!"

"Hmm? Oh! Yeah, sorry. Just realised, Adora's energy readings from the Frigate's sensors, when she went all scary murder-death-kill-kill, matched her ship's. Which matches the Velvet glove. Aaaand the data around Praetorian um… creation indicates the same energy format. Seems they're running the same software!" Entrapta beamed.

Catra blinked, "What?" She looked at Scorpia.

"Huh?" managed the Scorponi.

"AH," Weaver interjected, " *That… does not sound good."*

Chapter End Notes

So, there's some stuff being REVEAED and hinted at. Reasons why Adora was maybe drawn to the power. Why it WORKS with her. And what HAVE the Imperials been playing with?

Also Catra is GOOD at gameplaying and persuasion. Is Hawk easily swayed of course? We shall see.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Adora wakes up.

The nature of Praetorians, and other horrors

Plans begin to emerge!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Doctor Casta Moon stared at the readouts and shook her head in a mix of wonder and abject horror .

"How the *hell* is she still alive?"

Adora lay on a simple bed nearby, her chest rising and falling rapidly. Red veins appeared and disappeared periodically across her skin, vanishing under the torn clothing that she still wore. Casta hadn't tried to remove it - beyond being able to insert an IV and nutrient drip, any attempt to touch the woman had resulted in a violent spasm and a shriek.

Casta moved to a nearby cabinet and fished out another IV bag and nutrient canister, which she then slid into the receptacle next to Adora's bed. She lifted away the now empty bag and canister that had been in the *other* receptacle - she had to run a parallel system, as removing a bag or paste dispenser caused Adora to scream

again. She had to keep the flow *constant* . Casta moved back to her console and thumbed through the displays, then grimaced as the display flickered and the lights stuttered, "Damn power core. If this place had a half decent setup…" she sighed and shook her head, palms down on her desk.

They'd *have* that if they were maybe planetside, or had a decent supply chain - but to have that would mean signing up for Imperial rule, realistically. And *that* brought a whole host of other issues.

A sudden sharp gasp made her turn and she stared as Adora sat bolt upright. The blonde's eyes were open wide as she gulped down air like a drowning woman. Casta started forwards as Adora then began to yank the IV and feed-tubes out of her throat and wrists. She retched then staggered off the bed. Casta tried to grab at her but yelped in surprise as Adora's fingers gripped the front of the Doctor's tunic and lifted her into the air.

Casta stared into icy blue eyes as Adora croaked, "Food?"

"W e..we've been giving you paste, all..you need to lie down so I can do a full…"

Adora glanced around, wild eyed, then dropped Casta, who managed to find her feet and near collapsed against her desk. The blonde nodded absently, "I'm..on the base. Ok. Good…"

And with that, the woman was out the door. Shouts from the corridor indicated that the security detail outside had categorically *failed* at intercepting her. Casta thumbed her console and brought up the comm line, "Doctor Moon to command? Someone? Adora is… awake and, um… loose?"

She felt genuinely at a loss - was Adora a threat? She hadn't seemed it, but Juliet had been worried and Casta put a lot of stock in what Juliet thought… right up until she'd seen Adora's vitals.

" *Casta! Are you ok? Oh gods, did she…*"

"Hush, I'm fine. She's spooked and ran out of here. I ah… I *think* she's heading for the cafeteria."

"...what?"

"Hey, Glimmer here. I'm en route there now. Juliet, do NOT send troops. It… probably won't end well…"

—

Glimmer pushed past the crowd gathered by the entrance to the cafeteria. Crew and civilians loitered, nervous, not willing to enter. This was part of the crew-deck, not the main Promenade, which had

its own eateries (her bar included). She was thankful Adora hadnt bee-lined it to the public segments of the Hub.

She shoved a lanky reptilian out of the way and stopped, eyes wide. Adora was hunched over a table, trays of food products, cooked and uncooked, stacked and sprawled around her. She was chomping down on what looked like a bun and groaning with barely concealed delight. She glanced up and grinned as she spotted Glimmer. Her mouth was smeared with sauces and her cheeks were bulging.

" *Glim, ðo shud try ìs!* IS gd!" Adora chewed, then swallowed noisily, before she let out a loud belch. Glimmer glanced at a crewman nekto her .

"Uh.she' s not been here long, right?"

"Ma'am I think.ten minutes?"

"T en".Glimmer trailed of f and studied the *stack* of trays, "By the stars"…

With a shake of her head she made her way around the tables and approached Adora who was still scarfing down chunks of food. The girl was scooping it out of the plastic containers with her fingers and shoveling it into her mouth. Glimmer sat down opposite her and studied the blonde. Adora looked at her again, offered a brief smile,

then went right back to stuffing her face, only to let out another satisfied groan.

"You're um, putting that away." offered Glimmer.

Adora snorted, "Bio converter."

"Huh?"

Adora chewed and swallowed again, "Bio converter. I don't really *have* a digestive system anymore? Well, not a normal one," her eyes glazed over, "Watched them, uh, take it out. That was not fun."

Glimmer blinked, "Wait. what? You've. you've never"...

"Never spoken about it? Nah. Not many people know about us Praetorians. I guess you do, DT spilling the beans and all," Adora's smile was a little brittle, "But yeah, I'm a bit wired right now, may die any second so, what the *hey* let's just," she flung the tray suddenly across the room, the clattering sound sending the civilians scurrying away. A couple of guards at the door flinched, but froze as Adora stared at them, "Go on. Just *try*."

Glimmer turned and glared at them, "I said no troops. Go. Away."

The two exchanged a glance, then nodded and stepped outside the cafeteria. The doors hissed shut, leaving the pair alone. With the other ten empty long tables and the vacant line in front of the dispenser units, it felt eerily quiet. Adora blindly reached for another food tub and tore the seal off, before digging in. She stared at the wall, then paused and set the food aside with a grimace, "It'll do… for a bit."

"A bit?"

Adora grimaced, "Like I said…bio-converter. It's complex but, well…basically," her voice became saccharine and cheery, "As part of my '*training*' and '*induction*' to the glorious Praetorian Guard, I had some work done. On me," she hunched over, "They…rip out a lot. Replace other things. My muscles are organic, but enhanced. …beads and loads of micro-bots and nanites. I can push myself faster, harder. Reaction times go haywire. I can punch through steel. Hurts like a *bitch* but my bones are reinforced *and* they repair…Buuuut I normally have my suit."

"Yeah, I've…seen the vids."

Adora nodded, "Short version, the suit regulates my implants. It's a…feature. It's a control mechanism and limiter, but also allows us to *unlock* extreme enhancements for a short time, then automatically shuts them off. But, hey, the Imperial Horde loves just jacking in extra features. So, the suit feeds me enough energy to fuel my abilities. Outside the suit, they're shut off. I'm a regular, if slightly more resilient, person, right?"

Glimmer nodded slowly, "So…you activated them *without* your suit?"

"The Horde never expects anyone to actually *capture* a Praetorian. We're sort of *kill with extreme prejudice* priority targets if we're ID'd in open combat. For good reason. And we *are* killable. It's why we're used mostly as espionage, infiltration and guerilla units."

"Yeah...Why aren't there...legions of troops like you?" Glimmer frowned - there was a worrying thought.

Adora chuckled darkly, "Why don't the Horde just use fleets of Battleships? Cost. And tech. We're made using...well, proprietary stuff," Adora glanced away and Glimmer frowned.

"What aren't you telling me?"

The blonde shrugged, "Something that even I'm not one hundred percent about. I think it...it's tech that I'm familiar with and I need to find out more."

"Why? I mean, they...they violated you? Do...is it...do you need to know to fix yourself?"

Adora looked at Glimmer and smiled softly, "Fix myself? I guess so. But that was before this. It was...it's because the tech that made *me* ...and the other Praetorians. It's *not* Imperial."

Glimmer arched an eyebrow, "So...you're stuffed with what?"

"Tech that is beyond *most* Imperial designs. But I'm getting ahead of myself," she pointed at the food, "Need this stuff to keep the tech from eating me."

"Which the suit is supposed to stop?"

"YEP! And also because...because like I said it's a biomass converter. In extreme situations a Praetorian could become separated from its suit, or the suit damaged enough for the Praetorian to become vulnerable. And if that happens, it's usually because the situation is TOO dangerous for Imperial troops sooo," she winced, "We become a denial weapon."

Glimmer leaned back, "What...how does that work? You blow up?"

That got a slightly hysterical cackle from Adora, "No. We're terror weapons, tthat would be too risky. No we uh...we can choose to overload. And then well...we just need to keep fuelled."

Glimmer's brow crinkled as she took in Adora's wan expression. Then her eyebrows rose, "Wait...bio *mass* converter"...

"Uh huh. Any biomass. The more nutrient rich the better," deadpanned Adora, "And keep in mind *most* Praetorians are...pretty

fucking *gone* already. They're basically meat robots. Psychopaths on a leash."

Glimmer leaned back in her seat and stared at Adora, then the food plates, "Are you going to *eat* us?"

Adora stared at her, then snorted, "Nah, you're married," she waggled her eyebrows. Glimmer blinked then snorted loudly. Adora giggled, which escalated into a wheezing laugh. She waved as she calmed down, "No I'm uh it fucking *hurts*, which is what makes most Praetorians just go. Well to town. But I'm a *bit* tougher." Then she dug back into the food, "But srsly," she mouthed, "Th's helps with pain."

Glimmer winced, "Still bad, but enough regular nutrients means the bots eat that rather than *me*. And it means the coded directives pushing me to do *bad shit* aren't much more that tak."

"Tek?" Glimmer arched an eyebrow. Adora pointed at her eyes.

"Yep. Fuckin' annoying."

"Yikes."

"Yep."

"You need like an ad blocker."

Adora stared at the pink-hair girl, then laughed again. She shook her head and her shoulders relaxed. She stared at the table top, then whispered, "Thanks Glim."

"For what?"

Adora shrugged and looked around the room, "This place. I've… I've not exactly been the friendliest…"

"Well, we haven't been at our best either." Glimmer smiled and leaned on the table, "And my mom made a *huuuuuge* mess of things."

"I'm really glad I didn't have to shoot her," deadpanned Adora. Glimmer arched an eyebrow accusingly, "What! It wouldn't have been fatal! I'm not an idiot."

"Thanks I guess?" mumbled Glimmer, but she was relieved to see Adora's lips quirk in a small smile, "So…you're a techno cyborg zombie that's going to eat us if we don't feed you every twelve minutes or something?"

"More like I'm that until we get my suit back"…

Glimmer frowned, "Wait you mentioned going rogue. Surely the suit won't or *shouldn't* work? Given that you're," she gestured at Adora in a rather vague way, "*not* Imperial. You said it was a *lot* of tech, surely they'd have countermeasures. So why haven't you gone all cyber vamp before now?"

Adora gave a lopsided smirk, "That tech? That stuff is pricey buuuut they keep making Praetorians, yknow? Most of us burn out, the tech and imprinting just wearing the bodies down, eventually. Like I said, a lot of Praetorians are just meat puppets with the ability to creatively solve problems," she shuddered, "Others are… They enjoy it. There are *volunteers* for the programme… They regret it mostly, but then… make do. Make peace with it. But, well, we do have a high attrition rate. High risk, the fact they wear down, some just going rogue and deciding to just go manic on everyone. So, we have *handlers*, central intelligence services. THey track us. A full suite of countermeasures on the suits would be cumbersome and could risk us being compromised. Imagine if an enemy found out how to shut the suit down remotely?"

"But they're paranoid, aren't you a threat to *them*?"

"Yep, but we're sent out to the conflict zones, usually ground based. We have directives against harming Horde troops technically. Except that's easilly worked around because anyone *opposing* our mission or interfering becomes a target," Adora shrugged, "And Imperial command don't mind if local forces or a few hundred troops get ground to paste, so long as a high value target dies."

Glimmer shifted uncomfortably, while Adora paused to tip another tub up as she leaned back to just swallow it down. After another belch and an apologetic wince, Adora heaved a sigh. Glimmer reached over to touch the other woman's wrist, "You ok?"

"Not really but...anyway, what was I saying? Oh, yeah, so, The Intelligence teams *can* send out shut down codes, orrr, more likely… just send more Praetorians. That's the most reliable way to get a rogue. Most rogues don't try to escape they just...go off plan and become homicidal. I'm a rare case. The ones that do go rogue just drop off grid and the Horde usually...lets us go. The suits run out of power, our abilities will flare up without regular updates and treatments and, well, then you hear those stories of small colonies just vanishing."

Glimmer's eyes widened, "Praetorians?"

"Yep, older models, probably bulkier cybernetics, more unstable. ANyway, the suit is a regulator, but we need to check in for updates to nanites, firmware checks, organ failure or gene therapy to rebuild atrophied or damaged internal functions," she shrugged, "I'm...not as worn down, you could say? But then apparently I got some funky *new* stuff. And...well," she took a breath, then shrugged, "I also have *Swift Wind*."

"What's your ship got to do with it?" Glimmer frowned.

"Proprietary old tech, remember?"

"Wait...nooooo? They're the *same*?"

"Yep. Long story short, the suit can reset...this. But that'll just be a hold off. A horde COmmander with the correct authorisation could *maybe* tell me to stand down and THAT might work. Maybe. I heard one commander tried that and, well, the Praetorian interpreted it as an *'Intent to disrupt an ongoing mission via coercion,'* so just decapitated him and killed his entire Regiment over four days."

Adora chewed absently, staring at the wall. Glimmer swallowed nervously, then below out a breath, "I...I'm going to have to tell mom. And Juliet."

Adora winced, then shrugged, "I know. Because...if...I can't beat this, it'll likely eat me. And kill me. But there is a risk that...if...the nanites damage enough, I go brain dead aaaand the programming just takes over." She said it so smoothly, so nonchalantly, Glimmer was almost shocked. But then she saw Adora's hand shaking.

"That's...that's *not* going to happen, Adora."

The blonde turned her gaze to Glimmer and swallowed, eyes wide, "I don't want to die, Glim. I...I thought I did but...not like this."

"Why then?"

"Because…Because she."Adora dropped the food tub and slumped, elbows on the table, head in her hands. Her blonde hair cascaded through her fingers as she gripped her head, "I dont even *know* . I dont know if she..or what she."…

"Who?"Glimmer frowned.

"CCatra. I."…

"The enemy commander?She' s the uh, the one you went through training with, right?Y ou're sure it' s her"?

"Oh it' s definitely her. Ive know since the start. But I thought she was *gone* . But now turns out she's running the whole thing."

"And what?"

"She was sending me out of system. She has *Swift wind* and my suit and..and I think she was going to just..let me go. Or hand me over to Imperial Intelligence. Exxcept..exxcept if she knew who or what I was she shouldve had more guards or or or."Adora stuttered then sat up, "I have *no idea* , Glimmer, what she wants."

They lapsed into silence until Adora pushed away from the table and stood up, her face set. Glimmer stood up too, but more cautiously, "Uh..ok, you seem, determined?"

"No use being all..snif fly. Gotta be busy," Adora thumped a fist into her palm, "Gotta do *something* ," her eye twitched, "AH! The Horde soldier! Y es! Plan!"

"W ait!" Glimmer yelped. Adora froze and cocked her head. The pink-haired girl splayed her hands at Adora's burnt and torn clothing, "Maybe a..a change?"

Adora's grin was a little scary, "Nah, this works better ."

The blonde rolled her shoulders and strode towards the exit, Glimmer practically jogging to keep up, "Maybe we should, I dont know, check in with the med bay?"

"Nope, time' s a wasting and Im *fine* . What's Casta gonna do? Painkillers and nutrient paste and check my temperature, psh, Im *fiiiiine* . Fuelled up," Adora stumbled a little as she exited the cafeteria, which made the guards (Who hadnt retreated all that far) flinch a little. Adora shook her head and gritted her teeth into a smile, "Im *fine* ."

"Adora you need…rest, surely?" Glimmer tried. The blonde paused and cocked her head.

"Rest just means I stand still and burn through my reserves. I literally *cannot* rest like this Glimmer. This isn't…I'm not being self sacrificial, or 'pushing myself'. I. Will. Literally . Die."

The bar-woman stared into Adora's eyes, then nodded slowly, "I'll uh"…

"There you are!" the pair turned as Bow jogged up to them from down the corridor, "Heard through the comms, Juliet's asking for an update and she's steamed at you, Adora. You didn't…yknow…do anything to Casta?" he winced as he said it, "I mean I know you wouldn't but…I…dunno, unconscious sleep fighting?"

"That was ONE TIME at the bar!" Adora flung her hands in the air and the guards flinched again. Adora gave them a dirty look, but then turned her glare on Bow, who just held his hands up. The blonde sighed, "And, no, I didn't touch her . Just wanted food for… the pain and all that," she waved a hand dismissively then planted them on her hips, "So, where's the, uh…brig? Never , actually, yknow…been there."

"Not for want of trying," muttered one of the nearby guards, who froze as Adora leveled a finger at him, her face split into a sudden grin.

"YOU! Take me to the security office! That'll be where the cells are!"

"Are we, uh... Arresting her?" asked the second guard, who tipped his combat helmet up. The other guard swallowed and adjusted the blue webbing across white combat armour.

"I really hope not."

"NO! I need to talk to the prisoner."

"Ohhhh then... um, right this way?" Adora fell into step behind them. Glimmer winced and grabbed Bow's arm, whispering to him as they walked, giving him the broad strokes of what was going on. As she finished, he shot a concerned look at Adora's back.

"Are you ok?"

Adora slumped a little, then looked over her shoulder, "Nope! But unless you have a way to stave off chronic pain and negate the ongoing assault on my organs by hyperactive nanites before we work out how to get my ship back... Then I've just gotta keep going."

"Oooooh- *kay!"* Bow exhaled, then nodded. His face became a mask of determination and he stopped, which made Glimmer draw up short, which made Adora and the guards also stop. They blocked the

narrow corridor, the lights flickering overhead as another power surge vibrated through the construct, casting the rock walls in a weird grey-blue glow. Glimmer frowned at her husband.

"What does that look mean?"

"W ell, zombie Adora is a *bad* idea, so Im gonna go talk to Casta."

"Ehhh is that *wise* ? I mean, we probably need to talk to her *properly* ? So she and Juliet dont get the wrong idea."

"Nope, soonest is best. T rust me." Bow grasped for Glimmer 's hands, then looked at Adora, "Please?"

Adora shrugged, "I doubt you can make it *worse* . Not like anyone can do much." she turned back down the corridor , leaving Bow and Glimmer to share a quick kiss, before Glimmer darted after her friend. The group passed through an external corridor which had a view of space and Adora froze. She pointed out into the black, "UH… why is the *Sea Gate* RIGHT THERE?"

The guards and Glimmer exchanged glances and the barwoman coughed, "They warped here? Only enough"…

"Oh by the *Stars* that thing is a nuclear *beacon* ," Adora gasped. "Hells I can *see* the radiation."

"Wait, you can...nope nevermind...we *know* Adora. It's...it's why we need a plan."

"The station needs to be evacuated. You don't understand they *will* come. Catra always ranked highest on the strategic tests. Wargames, logistical mapping, all that. She'll be coming and coming hard. Soon. Crap, we have less time than I realised. Shit shit shit."

Adora spun and chivied the guards along. The corridor split and they moved inside the asteroid, descending several narrow stairs until they hit a storage bay. The security office was nearby, another converted hold carved out of the rock, split into a monitoring section and a caged off armoury. Adora studied it, then glanced at the access corridors. Glimmer looked at her, "What?"

"Defensible, some good access routes to the hangers *that* way, up to command *that* way and I think the Promenade sector *that* way...we took a bit of a ring route, buuut...it's at a key junction, recessed. So response times would be fine. Near airlocks. Assume there's..." she paused and shrugged, "This will be the secondary target beyond the HQ."

The guards exchanged glances, "Uh...what?"

"When they send in boarders. Since *most* of the life support is inside the station they'll have to board," Adora shrugged and smiled, "Horde doctrine usually stipulates targeting life support systems to

ensure rapid surrender on hard siege targets. If not possible, breach and securing command control nodes. Engineering will be another local target but depending on their weapon configurations, like if they have EMPS..well, they can disrupt that without needing to commit troops."

She trailed off as Glimmer stared at her. The woman nodded slowly, then looked at the guards, "Where' s Juliet?"

"Um..medical, I think?" Adora winced at that, but shook herself. Glimmer nodded.

"Get her down here. She needs to talk to Adora about security , defence and..damn near *everything* . Where's the Prisoner?"

"Uh..we have him in here. The doc gave him a check and then we secured him in um..storage bay 3. Got it converted to cells. Sort of."

They moved into the security station, with one guard hanging back to move into the monitoring station to contact their Chief. The group passed through a checkpoint manned by an armed guard in a haphazard looking set of powered armour . Adora frowned at it but nodded slowly, then followed their escort into a secondary set of storage areas. These looked more like small rooms, set up as interim barracks, and were surprisingly comfortable looking. He was in one of the cells, sat on a soft looking bunk, strewn with cushions. He had a bandage around his head and was drinking from

a flask. The room's door was open, but a guard stood by, leaning against the frame, chatting to the young man, "...so of course, well, my kid wouldnt..Oh, um hey Corporal..wait is that?..

The chatty guard straightened up. And he glanced up, then did a double take, "Ohhh noooo," he slid down into the cushions, eyes wide.

Adora pushed past the guards and grinned, "Heyyyyy . So. I think you and me..We need a *chat* ."

Chapter End Notes

So the next couple of chapters are allllll prep. A bit more Adora this chapter and next, well see whats in store for poor ol' Kyle!

What could Adora be thinking? How will Juliet react? WILL ADORA CONSUME ALL THE BIOMASS?

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Catra reviews her progress.

Adora makes a reqest

A plan begins to form!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Captain, we're in orbit. Do you want a shuttle prepared?"

Catra drummed her fingers on the armrest of the command chair before she shot a curt nod to the helmsman. With a huff, she stood and brushed down the front of her uniform, then adjusted the hem of the coat and turned to Scorpia, "Commander , you have the bridge."

Her XO nodded and winced, "Uh, any.specific orders?"

"Of fload the prisoners as per SOP's. But keep that madman in the brig. I think hell be useful. He spoken to the guards?"

"Not yet, ma'am,"Scorpia glanced around, "I dont think he will."

"He will. He knows we hold all the cards," Catra's eyes narrowed and her fists bunched, "He'll do it to save someone he cares about."

"How...how do you know he will?" the XO queried. Catra gave her a withering look.

"Because that's what *heroes* do," she bit back a further comment, something a little more guilty, which bubbled in the back of her throat, "It's what *good* people do," she sneered instead, "Now...I have an appointment with Entrapta."

Her walk through the ship didn't take long. The Destroyer was massive, much larger than her prior command, but she was well used to its metallic halls and dim lights. Old it may have been, but the vessel was still a formidable beast. A mirthless smile stretched across her face as she pondered thanking Octavia for her *kind gift* again. The woman was safely out of system, reassigned to some backwater elsewhere, according to her last communique from Governor Hordak. Clearly he felt Octavia's talents were *lacking*.

She emerged into the hangar bay where a blocky Horde transport stood waiting. The masked pilot saluted, then waited as she buckled up into a crash couch. The ship was a planetary troop transporter, a smaller variety. They had breach pods and larger assault vessels, but this one was more for rapid commando sorties. Or just ferrying people about. As the ship rumbled to life, she gazed out of the small porthole opposite, set between the chairs bolted to the vessel's hull. She watched the Destroyer come into view and then shrink, the other ships of the fleet arrayed in high orbit above their planetary stronghold.

The engineers had been thorough - they'd established a temporary orbital habitat - ideal for retrofits and refueling. It was little more than a webwork of scaffolding and cargo containers, but it was something that meant they didn't need to do direct ship-to-ship dockings all the time. The image vanished as the shuttle banked and then an orange glow flashed across the window as they punched through the atmosphere. Catra jostled in her seat, eyes glazing over as she pondered.

There'd been so many revelations. Adora, a Praetorian, being the most *shocking* , of course. The experiments, the reality of what the girl had gone through, were sickening and formed a pit in Catra's gut. The sudden shock of the possible connections of Adora's vessel? Even more madness. That Adora had taken a hostage was also just beyond belief. The girl had been kindness personified, even in the stringent and strict halls of the Academy.

She had changed. Catra had, as well, but she was having to reassess a *lot* of that. And now Adora likely wanted to kill her.

Does she? That thought was so unnerving it made Catra blink. It wasn't an external voice, but it was a *doubt* .

Adora could have let their ship slam into the asteroid. She could have, by the looks of it, broken through the brig forcefield and torn Catra in two. She could have infiltrated their ship and slit her throat. So many, *many* possibilities.

She'd let herself be captured. Oh, Catra knew they weren't *invincible* - clearly Adora had wanted a tactical advantage. Cunning, calculating. But *still* .

Admittedly that frigate had been on a collision course - but *again* Adora wouldn't have been able to target *that* accurately. Likely she picked the biggest target and got the base ship virtual intelligences to just autopilot to the largest mass. Maximum disruption to save her friends.

"Ma'am, we're in the pipe, five by five. ETA ten minutes."

Catra looked up as the pilot leaned around to wave through the hatch. She nodded, and sighed, eyes unfocussing again as she pondered the next set of news - that Adora's implants and, perhaps, some Imperial tech, were connected to some sort of weird *old precursor tech* from some random system?

It was so *cliche* . Precursor tech was itself some sales gimmick hacks and conspiracy theorists in the core worlds used to describe old methods of *pottery* making. Not terrifying Mech machines that could tear apart capital ships. It was *old* tech, how was it *better* ?

Catra groaned then shuddered as she felt the craft touch down. Through the window she could make out snow flurries as the planet's perpetual snowstorm raged. There was a distant hiss, followed by a mechanical *thud* and the snow abated, the light outside

fading only to be replaced with stark, electrical lights. With a huff, Catra unbuckled herself and stood, then made her way to the vessel's rear as the ramp hissed down. She gave the pilot a nod, then stepped out of the shuttle.

They'd landed in a silo, the roof above a sliding blast door . Snow was rapidly melting on the concrete floor, while technicians scurried about tending to other craft. The hanger was pretty vast, with several other blast doors above allowing for multiple launches. Off to one side, surrounded by several generators, cables and enough security to hold a small planet, stood Adora's stolen vessel.

Catra moved across the hanger and spotted Entrapta. The woman was sat among a pile of scraps, with other engineers gather around. She was briefing them on *something* , Catra couldn't be bothered to work out what. One of the engineers spotted her and saluted, going rigid, "Ma'am!"

Entrapta stared up at the engineer then turned her head and beamed, "Oh!Hey Catra!"her expression went thoughtful for a moment, "Oh!W AIT!CAPT AIN Catra!Phew , nearly in trouble there."

Despite herself, Catra smiled. She saluted the others present, then approached the machine at the center of all this. It was still covered in a strange, oil slick like sheen, while Entrapta's probes hovered nearby, silent sentinels. Catra pursed her lips and glared at the damnable thing, "So?"

"So?" Entrapta blinked and stood, "Um, so…what?"

"So? Any closer to cracking this thing? Does it run on unicorn farts and rainbows, or is it something we can fucking *use*?"

"W ell, ah, since we…since we have template energy signatures, I *have* managed to do some actual scans!"

"Oh. K Y. Great. So we can, what, know where it is?" Catra rolled her eyes, "WOW! I mean, I wouldn't have guessed it was *right there*."

Entrapta cackled, "No! I mean, we can see *inside* better. I mean, I have a full breakdown now of the engine, the energy and, well… what it sort of *does*?"

That got Catra's interest, "Oh yeah?"

"EP! It uses resonances and radiation, along with what *looks* like… Nanobots. EXCEPT EXCEPT EXCEPT! And here Entrapta practically danced a jg, "THEY'RE MADE OF LIGHT!"

Catra blinked, then sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose, "Ok, dial it back. They're *what*?"

f KNOW!"

"That is," Catra flung her hands up and glared at the machine, "That is straight up *bullshit* . This thing uses *light* to turn into, what… a death machine?" she snarled and pulled her captains cap of f to run a hand through her hair, "It' s a fucking *tug boat* that turns into a shitty *cargo lifter* and you're saying she stuck some sort of magical ball into it and it is now outclassing *capital ships* "?

Entrapta's grin grew wider, "YES! Amazing isn't it."

Catra's eye twitched, "No. It really *isn't* . How easy is it to find these damn things? Because if the rebels have *more* of them, they can turn any old garbage hauler into a *Capital level threat* ."

Entrapta blinked, "AH. Y es. I see the concern," she bit her lip, then shrugged, "W ell, I can assure you that, according to what records Weaver has provided, *plus* the sensor net we established, this is the *only* core of its type in the system and, likely, within the sector. Not sure why, records around their use are sealed at Intelligence Operative level only! So, um, I guess that' s because of the whole *super soldier squick* stuff?"

Catra exhaled, slightly relieved. She stared at the vessel and felt a strange stirring in her gut. It felt like she was being *scrutinised* by something, "W ell that's reassuring. Has it *done* anything? Powered up, down, whatever?"

"Well, funny you should mention it. It, um, it upped it's shields until a few minutes ago, just as the hangar doors opened. But there is something interesting - we were able to map the interior of the vessel and"…

"And it appears our Praetorian problem might be self solving," Weaver's smug voice came out of a nearby speaker. Catra's eyes narrowed.

"Explain."

Entrapta sighed and chewed her lip, "So, um, it would appear there is a smaller energy signature within that mirrors the Praetorian core signature *and* the main engine of the vessel. It's portable and is likely"…

"The Praetorian's suit," Weaver's voice practically bubbled with glee. Catra frowned.

"Wait, why is that important?" Catra felt something cold in her chest, something she'd read in one of those awful *awful* Project documents.

"Well she won't be as combat effective," murmured Entrapta, but she also looked uneasy.

“And she is more likely to be our asset. Captain, you can simply hold the fleet at range and wait for them to run out of food. And then this… Adora… will do the work for us. Her nanites will render her brain dead and then she will become the ultimate terror weapon. And then we… you *…can simply fly in and liberate their station and sweep up stragglers.”*

Catra licked her lips and twitched, "But…we need her alive. For… for access to this."

“No, on reflection, I believe with the headway Chief Engineer Entrapta is making, we may be able to simply… force the lock as it were. It may take longer, but with the rebels pacified, time is no longer a factor. The removal of the rogue Praetorian makes it even less so.”

The feline Captain swallowed, the awful feeling in her chest getting stronger, "That's leaving a *lot* to chance. If…if this is to do with, what…bio fuel?" she saw Entrapta nod, "Well, we don't know their supplies. We can't cover EVERYWHERE. Can't *stop* supplies getting in. And if I know Adora…" she squared her shoulders, "She'll *know*. And she *won't* let herself do that. She's a Praetorian but…she's still Adora."

“That seems… illogical. She would want security. She has no confirmed transportation, beyond a single strike vessel. Where would she go.”

"You dont *get it* . Shell either try to get here, if she knows where *here* is. But I doubt she knows the co-ordinates," she sighed and shook her head, "Or shell just... Sit in a container and let herself *die* ."

"How do you know she will?" sneered the voice of Weaver, " *One moment…. Ahhhhh yes. She did exhibit a level of selflessness. She was identified as putting the mission ahead of other concerns if provided with the correct motivating statement. Records are… incomplete however. Strange…"*

"See, so hoping shell just… *Kill* everyone is a non starter. And stupid anyway. We need to capitalise. Entrapta, can we *use* any of this?" she waved at the ship.

"Well, I can track Adora's signature. So, we can see where she is in real time. I imagine that's useful?"

"Being able to see where the deadly killing machine is? Yeah, just a bit," Catra chuckled, "Anything else?"

"Well.. I can pull together simple mirrored prototypes," Entrapta's eyes gleamed as she rubbed her hands, "I just need more spare parts. Can you spare a Frigate?"

Catra raised an eyebrow but decided to take a chance, "We've lost a few..can you use the *Shadow* ?"

"That'll do! We didn't junk all of it for the orbital... the drive should be functional still." Entrapta continued to ramble. Catra turned back to the machine and swallowed again. For the first time in years she suddenly felt *trapped.* Her choices felt like they had an undercurrent she wasn't familiar with - unpleasantness.

Before now it'd been shaking down merchants, or chasing down pirates. Keeping the peace, the *order* of the Empire. But now she was being told to consider things like *a human bio-weapon* or *sieging* a station. Great in the simulations, but up front it felt weirdly intense. She huffed and pushed the thoughts away, then nodded at Entrapta to continue. She stalked from the hangar into the corridors of the former research base.

Her feet took her to the communications hub, where a duty Ensign tracked the comms traffic for the orbiting fleet. The young woman looked up and saluted while remaining seated, "Ma'am, transmission from the new Frigate group in system. Confirming two *Ballista* class Frigates and two *Raptor* class assault frigates, courtesy of the Governor."

"Thank you Ensign," Catra managed. She looked around the Comms room - a couple of other troopers manned monitoring stations, listening to broader system traffic, "Anything else to report?"

"Uh, a burst of unencrypted signals, general SOS and confused status requests. The rebel forces appear to be in disarray, if we're to believe their open channels. We have reports from the picket fleet

near the last reported jump emergence for their capital ship, reports of patrolling sorties, but all similar configurations. Updates from Captains Hendricks, Leech and Kirk indicate no major movement of traffic, military or civilian."

Catra nodded slowly, "This has been pushed to ops?"

"Yes ma'am."

"Good. carry on. Oh and open a channel to my XO."

"Opening a channel, ma'am."

Catra picked up the proffered transmission microphone, "Alpha base to *ISS Retribution*,"

ISS Retribution, receiving Alpha Base, Send."

"Patch in Commander Scorpia."

"Aye, Alpha Base…." there was a hiss and Scorpia's voice came on the channel, *"Captain?"*

"Commander , send down our prisoner. I want to let him see why he should co-operate. Really drive the point home. Seeing is believing after all," she smirked, "Then he'll be coming back with me. Prep the fleet, we have four more vessels in bound to join the assault, I'll be finalising a plan here for a brief to all commands in the next six," she checked the chronometer on the transmission system, "Six hours. Prep all strike craft, all boarding shuttles and breach systems. We need to take advantage before the rebels can evacuate."

" *Aye ma'am. I'll brief the Captains. All hands on deck?"*

"One Frigate on planetary overwatch. The remainder to accompany the flagship. We've taken hits, we need to show them we aren't licking our wounds."

"Understood. Dispatching the prisoner . He should be down in the next 30 minutes."

"Good. Alpha base out."

The transmitter clicked off and Catra handed the mic back to the Ensign. She turned and left the room, willing herself to feel positive. A decisive push, that would get things *done* . She'd capture the base, capture Adora, and then…

And then sort all of this out. She'd tried to save Adora, but maybe she'd just have to force her to work with them again. Maybe if she got her to agree, they could get Imperial Command to waive

punishment? Convince them it was all a deep cover op to secure the reactor? Part of a plan?

She rolled her shoulders and stalked on, towards the Operations room. Either way, she would have a plan.

He stared, slack jawed, at the manic grin of the woman in front of him. He whimpered and leaned away. Adora tilted her head and then rolled her eyes, "Me. I just want to talk, ok?" she shrugged, "If I wanted to hurt you, I'd have left you on that ship, ok? Just talk, ok? Anyway, while *I could* shatter most of the vital parts of your body and leave you breathing I WON'T," she nodded reassuringly, "Because we are the good guys, ok?"

She gestured behind her to the nonplussed guards and a wide eye Glimmer. The barwoman nodded nervously, yet reassuringly, "Yeah, um, Hi. Glimmer! I'm Glimmer."

"O-oh! You're uh.. you're the girl that, um, bonnie.. uh?" He swallowed and glanced nervously at Adora. The blonde leaned back and nodded.

"Oh, she told you? Didn't think she'd let that slip. But then.. you guys are close, right?" her voice was softer. She paused and turned

to the guards, "Hey , so, um..can I get a drink please? And some more water for ykle here."

The young man frowned at her, "Uh, no of fence but I was, like… expecting" he winced and made strangled noises, followed by cracking sounds in his throat. Adora watched then grinned at him.

"I mean..I..get why? Oh and, uh..sorry about the head, seriously . I wasnt exactly ," she shrugged, "Entirely myself. So, um, ykle, right? ykle we need your help."

The blonde man frowned and slowly shook his head, "Uh..you.. .you killed my, um, my crewmates and now you want my *help* ?" he actually sounded affronted. Adora sighed and glanced away.

"I killed people who wanted to do bad things to me. And would probably want to do bad things to the people here. So, ykle..why'd you join?" The shift caught the man of f guard.

"What?"

"Why'd you join the Empire? The Imperial Horde? His divine majesty' s Invincible Army?"

ykle looked down and shrugged, clearly uncomfortable, "Why'd you want to know?"

"Because we're talking and, well..we can sit here quietly . Trust me, it's relevant," she gently prodded. Adora squatted down so she was at the same eye level as Kyle, "I'll tell you why I joined, ok? Street kid. Flushed out of an orphanage on the Capital. You know how it is, so many of us, right? Me and a good friend. And, well..I just tried to leave," she looked down, then spread her arms, "And now look at me! So, why'd you join?"

Kyle looked at her and swallowed, "Uh..similar , really. Parents died in a factory explosion..got taken in and, well, was assigned as basic crew. Didn't hit the advanced courses in the Academy . And, uh, well, it's a pay slip, right? And well, we're keeping the peace. Stopping pirates."

"Yeah, of course," Adora nodded, then stood, pushing upland rocking on the balls of her feet. She looked at the guards, "Mind if I borrow him? Come with, of course?"

The troopers shrugged and looked to Glimmer. She just shrugged in response, then nodded. Adora beckoned for Kyle to follow and he cautiously rose, "Where um..are you gonna"...

"No I am *not* going to space you. But I wanted to show you something," they walked out of the brig, past the armoury and out into the station proper. Adora led the man up stairs and through corridors to the main Promenade. It was, like most of the station, hewn from the rock of the roid, but had several viewing windows along the way. They paused at the bar. Glimmer peered in and

breathed a sigh of relief, noting that it was mostly full of tired looking crew and not antsy smugglers. Adora smiled and nodded at Kyle, "So, see all these people?"

"Uh, yeah?"

"So, they've been salvaging *that*," she pointed out the window at the *Sea Gate*, "Casualties, the dead, all that. Anyway, these guys… they're just mechanics, crew, longshoremen. Men and women," she towed him away, gently, to the next alcove, a tailor's shop, "DT here, well…they aren't here right now. But they're a *tailor*," then the next alcove, "And here, well, this is just a routine trader. There's a book store. Got some normal traders here, just day to day stuff, and, yep…here's a grocery store. We have a few fresh things like produce, yknow?"

Kyle blinked in surprise, then yelped as a couple of smaller children dashed around the corridor and darted away, "Uh…why are you showing me this?"

Adora watched the children run off with a smile, which shifted to a frown. She looked at Kyle, "So, you know what happens next, right?"

The young man stared up at her and swallowed, "You, uh…tortu-"

"Not with you. With this place. You know what the Horde does. Its doctrine, right? Siege. Hit life support. Storm aboard, full force."

"Uh, well, this is a..a...mil.. Military target."

"Hm, yeah. I mean it has *combat* vessels of independent individuals using it. And, I wont deny that there are elements here who have actively resisted the Horde. Buuuut..your *friends* , the same friends who wanted to spend some *quality* time with me, introducing me to their fists? They'll be smashing through airlocks and kicking down doors. Lots of smoke, lights failing, lots of movement and the assumption there are enemies *everywhere* ."

We stared at her . Adora's voice was airy, albeit quiet. She gazed out of the window for a bit and We swallowed, "Uh, so"…

"And, well..we could end up with more orphans. Some stray shots from a Frigate, a breach here or there?"

"Then..then surrender?" We managed.

Adora laughed, "Oh and how will *that* go? Are they going to bother checking who's a rebel, who's a pirate, who's a merchant just trying to refuel? Or will Catra' s troops just process everyone as *labour* "?

"She..she will be fair ."

"Maybe. But when the people in the transports get dropped at the next station? Will they be fair? Will they be processed? No. So, I won't let that happen," she turned to face Kyle and placed her hands on his shoulders, "Kyle. Your friends, those same people who won't care what's in their sights? They're going to come in guns blazing. People are going to get hurt. And I will hurt *them* to save as many people as possible. You *know* that your fleet aren't allowing *anyone* out. You know it. Because they want us bottled up. They won't *let* civilians go, under some excuse that *combat personnel* might flee. Any collateral damage will be written off. No one will care. You might feel guilty, a bit sad, but you'll move on. And these people will have dead friends, dead children. But hey, maybe you and, what was her name... maybe you and Bonnie get a promotion. Maybe they rescue you and you're hailed as a resilient hero who withstood our *barbaric tortures* . And you'll smile as they pin that medal on you."

She stepped back and Kyle stared up at her, "I... no, they'll... just surrender! There doesn't *need* to be a fight."

"You know that's not true. You've seen what *really happens?* Or do you see it through the lens of a drone pilot. Distant flashes and explosions? Venting atmosphere? Transmissions so full of static you can't hear the screams."

"Stop... just *stop*!" Kyle glared at her, "There... there doesn't need."

"Are you going to explain to people here that they should *trust* the Empire? That if they just roll over, they'll be fine? What were you and Catra doing before you came here? Just checking ship cargo? You

tried to shake *me* down. You seem fine with that. What's a few civilian casualties, right? All in the name of order , right?"

"STOP!" Kyle stepped up to her , his face snarl, "Stop. we… were…"

Adora leaned forwards, "I know . I believed as well. Which is why I need your help. I want to *save lives* . Horde and the people here. I don't *want* to kill them. I really, *really* don't," Adora's voice was hoarse, "I have seen too much blood. So, I'm asking… no, I'm *begging* you. Don't make me kill them. Don't. Let me *save* people. Please, Kyle."

He stared up into her blue eyes and swallowed. His eyes flicked to the weary people in the bar; the milling merchants; the rushing medical personnel as they shoved another gurney past, the other access-ways clearly clogged. His gaze turned to gaze into the black, where ships drifted and trundled - mining vessels, cargo ships, small shuttles. Kyle took a shuddered breath and looked back to Adora, "What do you want? I can't. I won't tell you where our base is. You'll just try to kill…"

Adora smiled, "Oh I *know* where the base is. No… no I need you to talk to Bonnie."

"Whwhy?" Kyle frowned.

"Because she is going to help you help me not kill everyone who sets foot on this base," Adora smiled, "So, will you help us?"

Sea Hawk stared at the vessel before him with despair, "You… weren't lying."

Catra chuckled, "Nope. Like I said, I wouldn't lie. We don't *want* to hurt anyone, we just want *peace*. Order. I get why your people are fighting, really I do. Frustrated, feeling abandoned. We can end this with the *minimum* of bloodshed. I am *not* lying - some people need to be taken down. Arrested. But they will be treated fairly. I'll ask for clemency, see if we can't keep them secured in system, not sent to industrial sectors across the Empire. Keep it local. Pirates... well, well list them as *combatants*, ok? No immediate executions."

Sea Hawk twisted to stare at her, mouth slightly open, "You... what?"

Catra gazed up at Swift Wind and shrugged, "Standard SOP. Pirates are... criminals engaged in terrorist activities. A commander's prerogative. But I'll make sure *all* your crew are treated well. Just work with me here. I just need you to help, ok? Talk to your friends, tell them to stand down, give us whatever intel you have on the main base so we know NOT to hit things like, oh, *habitation* or yknow… life support."

"You are a monster," Sea Hawk managed, wearily.

"Nope, I'm trying to *avoid* being a monster. You haven't got your angel to help and, according to my AI, she's not going to be in a fit state to *fight* on the ground... she may already be." Catra inhaled and kept her smirk in place, though it was hard, "*Dead*."

"You would like that," Sea Hawk rasped. Catra didn't answer, just gave a half-hearted shrug, "Well, I..." he squared his shoulders, "It is better to do or die."

"Fine, then I have to adopt Horde doctrine, which calls for saturated bombings. I have a *duty of care* to my troops. I can't risk this being a trap, that base being full of soldiers. Better safe than sorry. Thank you for confirming that," she turned away, Hawk still in the clutches of the two armoured troopers on either side of him.

"Wait!"

Catra paused and smiled thinly. She turned her head, "Yeah?"

"I can... I can tell you where... where the core military aspects of the base are. And... and which vessels are military. But you *must* spare the civilians. Leave them be! And... and I want a fair pardon for the crew and fair treatment for any who are captured or surrender. Leave for them to continue in the system, unmolested."

I cant pardon them. But I can mitigate. Alright" she turned around, "Take him to operations. Well finish fleshing out the plan with the help of Mr Hawk here."

She watched him being led away and shook her head. Naive, gullible, trusting *fool.* And yet she wasnt *entirely* lying. She looked down at the floor and growled to herself. She couldnt trust his intelligence. But she could use his *voice* . That was the next step - have him talk over an open channel, to try to convince the enemy to surrender. To get them to worry, to back down. Uncertainty in their ranks would help.

A sound behind her made her freeze - the hiss of an airlock opening. Slowly, Catra turned and stared at the captured ship. No one else was nearby, Entrapta having hauled her team off to the workshop to begin on some prototypes. She stared at the vessel, which had its hatch open. Catra blinked and felt her feet move. She had to stop her hand from reaching out.

It was *open* . She could just get in, take control, right? Unlock the whole damn thing?

But *why* was it open? How? She froze and noticed the faint blue glow from within the ship.

She blinked and then stepped back in shock. A black container now sat on the deck in front of her. It looked like a cargo case, with

strange indicators along its top - status readers, red EDs and a small screen. She'd seen similar carriers for experimental rifles or…

Combat suits.

She looked back up as *Swift Wind's* hatch hissed shut of its own volition, then she looked back down at the case before her. She exhaled slowly , her mind suddenly a blur. Then, with a glance to either side of her, she bent down and grasped the case, then moved towards the nearby shuttle that was to take her back into orbit later. She spotted the pilot doing checks and thrust the container into their arms, "Secure that. Ill need it back on the ship."

"Uh, aye aye ma'am. It' s..it' s not explosive?"

"No. Eqipment for the op. Just get it secured."

"Uh..aye aye."

And with that, Catra turned to head towards Ops. Her hands flexed and her breathing was coming in short, sharp breaths. Her mind was a sudden, confused whirl, "What. The. FUCK"

Chapter End Notes

Not long NOW!

And what is Catra gonna do... does Swifty know something?

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Everyone has a plan.

The pieces are being set.

Along with a few spanners.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stepped quietly into the controlled chaos of the base's control centre. Crew and troopers barely spared her a glance as she pushed her way towards the main console in the middle of the room. Status displays and large screens dotted the room, listing ship statuses, asteroid distances, enemy patrols, everything. The noise was a dull roar as dozens of voices all yammered at once, answering comms, sending orders.

The group in the middle was a stoic bunch, a silent eye of a storm. Angella stood, her arms crossed and her face set in a worried frown. Juliet scrolled madly through a tablet, cursing as she did so. Perfuma and DT stood, exchanging quiet words, while Glimmer chewed her lip, her gaze fixed on the floating hologram in front of them.

It showed the local area - dozens of asteroids, the main base and the damaged hulk of the *Sea Gate* . Small red dots blinked on the periphery - Horde scouts and probes. Adora winced as a spasm shot through her but rolled her shoulders. She saw Juliet fix a sudden,

cautious gaze in her direction and Adora waved a hand, "I'm fine. I've eaten and...and had a dose of iron supplements. I'm fine."

"Not you I'm worried about," grumbled the security chief. Adora took note of the seven guards around the room, all fixated on her. She snorted, but said nothing. If it came to it, she'd try her damndest to *let* them shoot her. She kept it to herself, of course and nodded up at the image.

"So, what's going on?"

Juliet's mouth twisted, but she just sighed and tapped the tablet again, "As I was explaining to the Commander, we can see they're probing our defences. But they haven't committed yet. We haven't identified a solid idea of *where* the attack might come from."

Adora nodded, "And no safe avenue to evacuate because of that. We launch ships, they could warp in and cause havoc. We sit tight, they have us buttoned up."

Juliet nodded, "Precisely."

"Are we sure we need to evacuate?" mused Angella. She met everyone's stare, "I know it is the *sanest* option, but we need to consider *all* options. I do not want to put our people, our allies, in unnecessary danger. If we can make this a defensible option, it

needs to be considered."

"Mom, they have fleets, supply lines. We'd be stuck here. A siege ends when one side gets bored or the other side starves," Glimmer shook her head, "It's not viable."

Angella regarded her daughter, then nodded, "Very well. So"…

Adora interrupted, "Why not both" she stared at the hologram. The others exchanged glances, "I mean, why don't we fortify? More than we are?"

"Well we're going to have to, to buy time for people to escape," Juliet enunciated, as if talking to a child, "We know we're going to have to fight."

The blonde smiled and gestured at the screen, "We know that. But what is *their* objective?" she looked at the group again, "Do they want to capture, or destroy? So far, everything leans towards *capture*. This is a prime facility, useful. They didn't take out the fuel depot, the formerly pirate one. They've been hounding civilians but, ultimately, letting them be. If they have the right *paperwork*. But I bet they want this place as intact as possible. You don't get intel from molten slag."

Juliet blinked then chuckled, "I mean, we guessed that… but saying it out loud, I suppose you're right."

Adora nodded, "So, troop transports. They won't park that destroyer on top of us. They'll send in troops. And before that they'll want to clear the way - so, drone swarms. Nullify fighter contingents, disable ships in the local area, send in the troops, then fight their way to our vulnerable points," she pointed out the power centre, security centre and control room on the zoomed in hologram, "Standard Horde doctrine - overwhelm. Cat- their commander follows it *mostly* but I reckon we should expect surprises. She's likely going to focus on capturing the station... and me."

Angella quirked an eyebrow, "Well seeing as you have a certain *providence*, hardly surprising, my dear. So, you are a vulnerability?"

"And... an asset. The Horde knows what I am. Which means I am a priority target. So, I stand to be the thing they focus their efforts on neutralising. Of course that leaves the drones."

DT took a moment to chuckle and lean forwards, "Oh I think we have that covered. We swamp the area with as much static as we can - drone transmissions get jammed, we end up with so much floating scrap. Of course it means our *own* comms will be spotty *at best*. And if they use laser-comms"...

That got a guffaw from Adora, "Hundreds of drones... they haven't got enough laser transmitters to control them with nuance. They'll end up on base AI control and those things are *basic*. But we need to make it harder for them to get troops in... and for our people to get *out*."

Angella nodded, "So, suggestions? With all our casualties, we are running out of space. I can see the Horde taking advantage of civilians in the base. Human shields, hostages"…

"How about…we uh…we uh get them of f the base?" That came from Perfuma. She smiled wanly as everyone looked at her, "W e have functional ships. Couldn't we…move them out? Evacuate, like you said?"

"They'd be intercepted if we sent them out now ," harrumphed Juliet.

"No, I mean…in the battle. Once the Horde arrive, well…we will know where their ships are then, right? W e could get the ships to just…leave on the opposite side of the belt? They can't surround the whole thing."

Adora raised her eyebrows and looked to Juliet who nodded slowly, The Chief of Security sounded unsure when she spoke, "W ell, yes… but they have probes - they'd see us launching ships. Or be able to read them, when they arrived…"

"What if we…have them run at low power? Have them sit around the base, hide in or around the asteroid?" Glimmer interjected, ex itedly .

"They would still try to intercept," huf fed Juliet.

"Not if we delayed them. The drone interference is one way to limit it. We need to stop frigates and manned fighters. What do we have?" Adora looked around, then back at the hologram. Her eyes fixed on the sea gate, then the asteroids, "Do the guns on her still work?"

"Um, maybe?" Juliet frowned, "But the hull is deadly. Radiation, no atmosphere."

"Do the guns need to be *attached* to work? We have spare power units, right?" Adora smiled, "And you have an entire cargo bay worth of ores and gas."…

"And?" Juliet frowned.

"And *mining charges*?" Adora prodded. Juliet frowned then blinked and grinned.

"Booby traps in *space*?"

"Exactly. A few cargo containers set up to blow? Stick some asteroid thrusters on them we can create an impromptu minefield. They may respond more aggressively, but it *will* buy us time to get the civilians clear. Then we can pull the troops in, lock their focus on the base."

Juliet cocked her head at Adora, "Sneaky ."

Adora shrugged, "Survival. How' s our fighter compliment?"

"About twelve, with five privateer ships left that are fully functional. Pirates have had some mechanical issues. And our fighters are just shuttles with chain guns strapped on."

"And our purloined Horde fighter ,"Adora rubbed the bridge of her nose, "Alright, Ill have to be out there to start with."

Glimmer stepped forwards, "Adora, you cant fly...not like this."

"No choice, Glimmer . And Ill be fine. If I get iced out there, at least I cant hurt anyone here,"she managed a lopsided grin, "Win win, right?"

Juliet had the good grace to look embarrassed at that. Perfuma coughed and smiled, "About that, Adora. Bow , Casta and I, well"…

"SURPRISE,"Bow jogged into the command centre, Casta on his heels, "W e're just about done!Just need to calibrate it to you Adora," he held what looked like some sort of breather mask, attached to a belt and harness, adorned with capsules. Adora blinked as the Engineer approached her, all smiles.

"Uh, weren't you with Me?"

"Oh yeah, we got him all set up with that jury rigged transmitter near the core. He reckons he can reach Bonnie with it. No idea what you're gonna expect her to do, but I have *faith*," he grinned, then proffered the strange harness, "SO, gonna try it on?"

"What is it?"

Casta clapped her hands and leaned around Bow, "Praetorian pain suppressor, home made edition! PPSHME! Still working on the acronym. Not quite hand knitted, but, well, stick around and we'll include you!"

Angella gave a good natured groan and Juliet chuckled. Adora saw the fond way the security chief stared at the Doctor and felt a pang of jealousy. Something she had never experienced and, really, never would. She shoved the thoughts away and looked at the device. It had strange metal hooks around the belt that looked painful. She arched an eyebrow at Bow. He smiled ruefully.

"Couldn't think of a good way to administer the electrical pulses. We have adhesive pads, but they could slip. Those won't puncture skin, but *will* deliver a charge. And"…

"...coupled with the inhalation rebreather there, that should both nullify the pain, encourage cellular durability *and* inhibit nanite movement and progression."

Adora blinked, then stared at the device, "It'll...it'll stop the pain?"

Caste smiled, "Yes, dear. It's not a *permanent* solution, but it has enough charge in there to last days, and can be topped up. Likewise with the cocktail of stims. Obviously, prolonged use may mean your system adapts to it. But we've designed it so that it administers things in irregular enough doses your system *shouldn't* quickly build up resistance. Of course," and here she looked a bit pained, "it will mean you won't be doing any of that," Casta made several chopping hand motions, which drew a snort from Glimmer and Angella.

The blonde blinked, "Ah. Yyyyeah. Going to need to punch *some* things."

Juliet quirked an eyebrow, "You just said you'll be flying?"

That made Adora chuckle, "I may need a change of scene," she took the harness from Bow and smiled, "Thank you. I...honestly, this is," she swallowed, then took a breath, "I'll get it on before we start."

Her friend grinned and winked, "Good. So, what's going on?" She looked to Juliet, then Perfuma, "No crazy genetically engineered plants to set on me? Man eating potatoes?"

Perfuma snorted, "No. Just the throwable kind. But we've processed all the medicinal plants we can, I've got the seed stores and hydroponics as reinforced as we can."

Bow shook his head, "So, we're fighting?"

Angella nodded, then looked at the schematic again, "We will need your crews on double shifts, Bow. Adora and Juliet have some rather *nasty* plans," she smiled thinly, "And what are you hoping our new friend will accomplish, Adora?"

The blonde shook her head, "Not sure *precisely*. But enough to cause problems for the enemy. It's enough if we can make them falter, make them second guess their aim. The officers won't flinch. But a soldier? Groupthink is how they roll. We sabotage some of that, even a bit? Ships won't launch, weapons don't lock, maybe they are more cautious? Maybe we get some access codes and we can cause a bit of chaos another way," she shrugged, "We can light the match. Our own plans won't hinge on it, but it's a bonus if it works. Just plant that seed."

Angella nodded, then looked at the group, "Well then, I suggest we all prepare. I doubt we have long."

Catra drummed her fingers against the holo-table in front of her. She was in her ready room aboard her flagship. A cluster of senior officers, some holographic, most in the flesh, stood around the large display. A floating asteroid belt hung there, fuzzy and indistinct. Catra glared up at it, "So, the probes haven't managed to get a definitive layout?"

"No," purred Weaver's voice from a speaker, *"Their sensors are not the best, but we have suitable insight from distant scans. An attempt to close a probe in for better visualisation was partially successful, but the level of signal traffic and vessel transit has made objective identification more difficult."*

The Commander smirked, "Still stripping that wreck, huh?"

A chuckle rippled among the Captains. Weaver continued, *"It would appear so. The majority of their actions were casualty extraction. Now they appear to be salvaging the vessel. Or retrofitting it. Also, the enemy is moving cargo into open space. I surmise they are making room for casualties or for vessels in the interior."*

Catra frowned, "So, the Cruiser is still a possible threat. They could use it as a static emplacement. Cargo...well that'll be obstacles fro our ships - create an unsafe route for boarding shuttles. It'll be tighter the closer our ships get. Lines of sight?"

She spun the image. Several asteroids clustered around the main base. Catra hissed. One captain coughed, one of the artillery frigate

commanders, "Ma'am, we can splinter the roids. Of course… collateral is likely. Looking at the briefing notes, capture is the order of the day?"

The feline shot him a look and straightened, "Yes. Blowing up a massive rock is probably not effective at getting them intact." She arched an eyebrow, but smiled, "But I'm not an artilleryman. Can you disrupt, clear a line of sight? If we want to keep at range, we need to remove *some* of the closer rocks."

The man nodded, "The right payload, we can knock them away . Which will cause more chaos for the defenders as they then have a rogue rock in their flight plans. A good opening gambit."

Catra nodded, "Good. They'll have static emplacements and fighter cover. We need to neutralise both, as well as keeping an eye out for the Praetorian. If she's gone rogue," Catra, somehow , kept her voice steady at that, "Then the seizure of the station becomes a *longer term* plan. No sense putting the men at risk. We seal and pull back. If not..well, she is a priority target for *capture* ."

The Captains nodded. They were all aware of the risk there. One coughed, "Ma'am, our deployment disposition?"

"Getting to that," Catra harrumphed. She tapped a button on the console. Horde symbols appeared, "Flanking. We come at them from three directions. Artillery and Capital group *here* , assault frigate group A here, group B *here* . Drones launch, frigates move into close

support after the artillery group disrupts their little rock defences. We cant do *too* much - itll make things harder for us. But we clear a few , gives the frigate groups maneuver options. Then, once we have clear skies, assault troops head in. We need to seize the hangar , but also breach some of the airlocks. Multi-entry to spread their defences. I want commandoes in first, marines next, use their heavier armour to tank the defenders hits, then secure vital points. Again, the Praetorian shows her face, do *not* divide forces. Counter doctrine is massed fire. Do not let her flank them."

"Any actionable intel on the layout, ma'am?" another Captain chimed in.

"Some. Not in depth. Our helpful associate only gave us core areas. I am minded to *not* trust the information completely. We do know they have no reinforcements. Their refueling base is just miners, no need to worry about that. Aaaaand we have their most powerful ship in custody," she grinned at that, a little forced, but still, "We ll play a little bit of psyops on them too. If they stand down, then we can avoid unpleasantness."

"Oh I hope they dont," chuckled a large, heavyset reptile. He was one of the Marine Captains. Catra eyed him as he cracked his knuckles. More chuckles echoed around the room.

"Yeah, let's *not* slaughter a whole station, ok?" Catra fixed the man with a glare, "Because, while we do the whole *scary empire* tactic, we dont need martyrs. *Someone* will survive and escape. And they tell everyone we butchered a whole station? You ll see rebellions pop up *everywhere* . Because if they know theyll die whatever happens then theyll fight *nastier* . So, dial it back, take down the

hostels, but *secure* the people. We need them," she smirked, "Unless you want to run the mining rigs?"

The reptile growled, but backed down as others laughed. Another captain chimed in, "He wouldn't know which end you were supposed to stick into the rock!"

"Silence, flyboy," snarled the reptile.

"Make me, mud-chewer"…

"Alright! Enough service banter," hissed Catra, "Save it for the enemy. We need prisoners. Intel, an idea if their network goes elsewhere. Access to any intact systems on board. Plus this could be a good way-station for shoreleave. We need people to serve the drinks, right?"

That got a round of cheers. Even the reptile, Captain Kobra, Catra recalled. She tapped the table and drew everyone's attention again. Weaver chimed in, " *Pay attention for signal codes and order of battle direction…"* Weaver paused, *"Captain there…"*

"Yes?" Catra frowned at the speaker. Weaver had paused.

“No. A minor diagnostic issue. Resolved. Please ask your engineer to cease her ministrations on our systems. I am getting duplicate entries and false positives.”

“Are they threats?” Catra tensed. Weaver actually *snorted* .

“Hardly. A serious invasion I would be able to alert you. Now, to the matter at hand. Order of battle…”

Catra relaxed. Weaver was an ass, but she’d shown she’d panic if there was a *real* threat to herself. She focused in as the AI laid out their battle plan.

Bonnie sat at the helm and fidgeted. Scorpia had had her on one duty or another for the past day. Barely any rack time. She knew what they were doing - keep her focused and she wouldn’t *worry* .

It was oddly considerate, whilst also being exploitative as anything.

She looked over at Rogelio, who manned her neighbouring console. He glanced at her and offered a reassuring hiss. She smirked, “Well aint you a ray of sunshine?” he shrugged and hissed again, “You need to get that translator sorted, you know that? Can’t keep pretending ignorance. Captain’ll get annoyed eventually .”

The lizard man shrugged again, then returned to his screen, maintaining their vessel's course. Lonnie sighed and turned back to her own console. She frowned and adjusted one of the sensor readings. Cocking her head, she turned and looked back at the other stations. No one seemed to be reacting. Slowly, she returned her gaze to the readout.

Her console had helm controls, but also rudimentary sensors for navigation-vital inputs. You couldn't always rely on the other stations to report in and advise in the middle of battle, or even on a shift. So, she had radiation pulses, radiowave sensors, the lot. Not as advanced or diagnostically enabled, but still.

Currently they were on a heading towards the asteroid belt. And she was seeing a pulse. A regular pulse. To anyone else, it looked like randomised signal noise, no audio. But she recognised the pattern, regularity.

It was her name. And Rogelio's name. And Kyle's name. Then a sequence of numbers. It was radiation pulses - powerful. A transmitter hooked up to a *big* power core.

Had Kyle escaped? Or was he being... Lonnie swallowed. Adora had taken him for a reason, she'd said. She glanced to one side and saw Rogelio staring at her in confusion. She shook her head slightly and returned his stare. Would he say anything?

The lizard man regarded her for a moment, then nodded slowly .

"All ok, helm?"

Bonnie startled, then turned in her seat. Scorpia sat in the commander's chair, looking at her curiously, "Oh, uh, no ma'am. Thought I had something on sensors. But Im.. uh..Im jumpy ."

Scorpia nodded in understanding, "Worried about your friend, huh? I get it, I really do. I mean, if Catra was out there? Well, hoo boy, Id be a mess. Well, not that much. Im still a professional! But, well, we'd be going in there guns blazing. Which would be a *bad* idea..but we are going to go in guns blazing soon. Well get him back, dont worry."

The big woman smiled at Bonnie, who returned it wanly , "As you say ma'am."

"If you're jumpy , head down to med-bay. Get a check. Rogelio, take her down, ok? Rik, Janek, take over helm."

Two other ensigns darted forward and slid into the seats Bonnie and Rogelio vacated. The Leutenant swallowed, "Ma'am Im fine. No need."

"I need you focused, Bonnie. I trust you, but we don't need someone itchy at the helm. Get yourself checked and report back. Rogelio, keep an eye, ok?"

The lizard nodded and the pair marched from the bridge. Scorpia nodded to herself, content that she was being a *good leader* . Catra was always suspicious, but Bonnie was a professional. She was bound to be antsy. But she was *solid* .

Bonnie and Rogelio took the access stairs down a couple of decks, then headed for med bay, but split off into a side corridor and hunkered down. Bonnie looked at Rogelio, "Ok, you saw that right?" He nodded, "I think. I think that was a radio frequency . We need to test it. Can you get to the comms room? I'll head to med bay . I think I think W eaver's watching me."

Rogelio glanced up and around. The ship wasn't completely covered with cameras - just a *lot* of it. Slowly, he stepped forward and embraced Bonnie. It looked, to an outside observer , like one crewmate comforting another. They whispered a plan out, then broke apart. Before splitting, they checked their issue comm-pads, for shipwide communication, then moved.

Rogelio darted away, heading back up towards the bridge. He peeled off, and stepped into the ships main transmission room, Idly, he moved to a terminal and slid into place, waving away another Ensign with a bored hiss. The other trooper shrugged, then went back checking another terminal. Quietly , Rogelio tuned the transmitter. A split second later a strange, garbled voice came over the line, more static than voice, with a strange cadence that sounded like it said *Privacy* . The terminal flickered and the status lights

blinked erratically. Then Kale's voice cut through, "*Bonnie… did… did it work?*" In the background, a muted female voice could just be heard, indistinct, "*I don't know! I'm asking… uh, this is, uh, Ensign Kale. Bonnie? That you?*"

Rogelio growled back, affecting a formal tone.

"*Oh! Big, Oh by the stars so good to hear you! I miss you b… um… buddy. So, yeah I'm uh. Well I've been captured. And don't roll your eyes. I can hear you rolling your eyes.*"

The lizard grumbled, then fished out his tracker. He rapidly tapped out a query to Bonnie and pressed send. *Kale ok.*

"So, um… I'm supposed to talk to Bonnie. Is… is the line secure? Are you alone?"

Rogelio intimated that accessing a long range comm *alone* was very unlikely. Of course, him speaking in Reptar did mean that the other comms officers were oblivious, or at least disinterested. It sounded like Rogelio was running through checks.

"Anyway, um… so… yeah. Turns out this Praetorian isn't going to gut me! Yay? But, look Rogelio… there's civilians here. A LOT of civilians and I'm. Oh stars, I can't believe I'm thinking this… I don't want them to die. It's different, being here. And, uh… I don't want

you to die. Or Bonnie. Or anyone. And Adora, the uh, the Praetorian… she's going to kill a lot of people."

Rogelio tensed and managed a polite enquiry that sounded like a normal radio check on *status* .

" *I'm ok. They're treating me well. Treated my injuries. And well… they seem like just people, big. Yeah there's soldiers here but I can't see it as a rebellion? And, stars… I think. I think we're the bad guys?"*

Rogelio rolled his eyes, then made a *loud and clear* sound, along with an *obviously* .

" *No! I mean, law and order. But these people were doing ok! And… it's going to get bloody. I don't want you to get in trouble but… oh I feel… I can't do this Adora…"*

Another voice came on the line, " *Hi. Adora here. Praetorian. So, first of, Kyle is fine, not going to hurt him. Second, anyone who sets foot on this base I will carve into pieces. Third… if you can delay anyone, or at least give us an idea of what to expect, I will do my damndest to MINIMISE casualties. We just want the civilians safe, ok?"*

Rogelio swallowed then warble a query of *should I bring this to the Commander's attention* ?

“No. Well, you can. We’d rather you gave us an idea or helped out some other way. I am NOT expecting you to scuttle the ship. Free some prisoners, give us comm codes. Anything.”

That made Rogelio frown, and he warbled about the prisoner.

“Hawk’s… alive?” Adora trailed off, *“Put to you then. Use this frequency to send what you have. If you don’t, well… I won’t harm Kyle. But he will be with the civilians, so I hope your boarding troops don’t get trigger happy. We’ll keep him as safe as we can. But… anything you can do. Once this is done, he can go wherever. As you can imagine, we’re kinda limited in terms of just letting him go.”*

The lizard man refrained from commenting about how she hadn’t needed to take him in the first place. No doubt the Praetorian would have a rejoinder. He startled slightly as Bonnie slipped into the room. She looked wan, “Just uh, got some meds from the doc. So, back to the bridge?” She leaned down, “Anything?”

Rogelio warbled that they were talking. Bonnie’s eyes widened and then pointed at the cameras, indicating *WE SEE YOU*. Rogelio shrugged and stated that the Praetorian had done *something*. He quickly brought Bonnie up to speed. She stared at him, then back at the console.

“Transmit the comm codes. And let us think. Give her our own comm pad frequencies, too.” Rogelio’s eyes widened. Bonnie met his gaze,

"Something feels weird, Rog. She could've killed me. She could've killed *all* of us. She's going out of her way not to. I'm not betraying the Empire. Catra's got that place nailed, we're gonna win. But if we can get Kyle out and save some lives? I owe that Glimmer girl that much too."

Rogelio looked into her eyes, then nodded once, then relayed the message, with several code confirmations.

"Acknowledged. We'll be in touch."

The terminal went silent and then flickered again as another weird vocalisation came over it. Rogelio and Bonnie left the comms room, then headed for the bridge. Bonnie stared straight ahead, "What the hells am I doing?" she murmured.

A few hours later, Catra lounged in the flagship's command chair, fingers clenched into the arm rest. Her mind was going a mile a minute, "Helm?"

Rogelio turned and warbled out an *About to drop into realspace.*

Catra keyed a button on her chair, “All hands, prepare to engage. Forward batteries charge. All ships, follow the plan, identify your targets. Await instructions as the situation develops, but otherwise engage in accordance with the plan.”

With a flash, the forward display faded into real-space, showing the cluster of asteroids that stretched across their vision, a thin line of rocks. Scorpia inhaled, “Here we go then”…

Catra bared her teeth, then stood. She cracked her neck and moved away from her chair, then glanced at the Bridge communications desk, “Open a channel. And someone haul our prisoner in here”?

The screen was static, then resolved into a grainy image of a control centre. A cluster of people stood about the place, clearly oriented so she couldn't see that actual layout of the place. A tall, willowy woman regarded her frostily, along with a dumpy, pink haired woman, a clear security guard and, finally…

Catra managed a snarl like grin as she planted a hand on her hip, “Hey , Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

And soon. It will clash.

Thanks for your patience all!had a bit of a slowdown as I handle my youngest who has had a bit of a growth spurt!Plus work!

This one was a bit of a blocker as it is all AI AI setup.

Next chapter is raw CHAOS.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

The board is set.

Exchanges are made.

A short calm before the storm.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's glare made Catra flinch, but she masked it with a roll of her shoulders as she affected a bored stance, "So, let's keep this really *really* simple for you backwater hicks. You are *clearly* in violation of a whole *bunch* of Imperial laws. I don't have time to list them. You're curious, my AI can send you the freakin' list. In short, stand down your warships, have all military personnel surrender and lay down their arms and have your civilian population ready to be processed," she folded her arms, "If you don't resist I will *guarantee* that the civilians will not be...redistributed...out of the system."

She watched Adora's jaw clench but, surprisingly, it was the willowy woman who spoke, "*Unacceptable. The Horde is not known for honouring its deals.*"

Catra tutted, "I think it's *more* than acceptable. You have attacked Imperial assets; you've acted as a bastion for *pirates* and, to cap it off, you are holding a top tier Horde weapon," her eyes flicked to Adora, "So, let's make this *even simpler* for your tiny minds. You surrender to me. This goes nice and smooth. Your soldiers are taken

away, imprisoned, work camps.you know the drill. BUT they have a *chance* ,"Her smile got nasty , "Or you *don't* surrender. This gets ugly. And if you manage to beat us off, which you wont, then the Horde comes back with *more* . To get *you.* "

She leveled a finger at Adora and shrugged. Adora just exhaled and looked away. The willowy woman frowned. Then the pink-haired woman spoke up, " *Still not buying it. You take Adora, you take us… then throw us into some off world torture camp. We KNOW what the Horde does. If we go down, we choose our own deaths."*

Catra scoffed then beckoned to one side, "We arent *monsters* . Cut us, dont we bleed and all that?"she shrugged, her expression still carefully held to look bored, "We take prisoners. We dont do things *mindlessly* . Without a goal. Unlike *you* . Violence, murder, chaos, for what end?How many *families* have you harmed, huh?"Shes sneered at the image before then, smiled as SeaHawk was pulled into frame by her ?, "See. Alive and well. We have a few others, all safe and sound in our brig. Now, Mr Hawk, why dont you tell them? Or dont. I wont force you."

She stepped to one side and gestured to the image. Hawk swallowed and glared at Catra, then looked at the screen, "We havent been.treated poorly . Medical care, feeding.they've upheld their side. What happens *after* this, however, I do not know".he looked down, then up and licked his lips. His next words came out at a rush, "They're going to go for the core!They want to capture as many civilians as possible!You need to escape!Dont fight!Just ru-"

He was cut short as Scorpia hauled him backwards. Catra *laughed* and wiped at her eyes theatrically, "Oh wow , totally didn't see *that* coming," she smirked at the camera, "See? I'm not the one breaking my word. You pirates... you're the villains here. I was even trying to get little-miss-killer there out of the way *nicely* . And what does she do? She *kills my men* ."

Adora met Catra's gaze, "*Maybe don't employ people who wanted to assault me in my cell then. Or maybe you did want that? Hard to tell, given where you got me sent."*

Her voice was cold. Catra swallowed as those blue eyes fixed on her. She blinked in surprise at the *seriousness* . Adora wasn't lying.

Maybe she hadn't exactly *vetted* the people she'd sent out there. She had just expected them to follow orders. Miscalculated on *that* front, definitely. But she couldn't allow for that now . She had to keep moving forwards. She managed to school her features, "You know what she did, right? You know how *dangerous she is* ."

That she addressed to the others on the screen. They managed to not make their discomfort obvious, but it was there. Catra smirked, but it faltered as the pink-haired annoying one spoke up, "*Yeah. We know. And she volunteered to fly right out of here."*

"Maybe you should've let her?" Catra spat before she inhaled. Her eyes fixed on Adora again, She couldn't admit over an open channel *everything.* She'd already shown she had *tried* . She rubbed her

eyes, "Look, make this easy. Adora, tell them to surrender. I *promise* we will be fair. I don't want a bloodbath. You don't. We do this, it will get *ugly*."

Adora cocked her head, clearly unsure. Catra watched the blonde and tried to stifle the ache in her chest, the guilt that gnawed at the back of her mind, "*You were sending me…*"

"*Away*, Adora. Away. That. Was. All." She emphasised the words. Adora frowned, then looked away and sighed.

"*You know… you know you can't keep that promise. You know that*."

The others were watching their play by play. Catra sighed and shrugged, theatrically, "I tried."

"You're right though," Adora interrupted. Her gaze met Catra's, *"It will be a blood bath. Just… let the civilians leave Catra. Please."*

Catra hissed, "And let your friends there sneak off officers, spies and key personnel? They are *terrorists*. I am being a hell of a lot more courteous than *any* other Horde commander you're gonna run into, Adora. Let us board, vet the people and we will let the non-combatants go, no harm. But your people need to stand down and *you* need to surrender. Peacefully."

There was a commotion on the other end of the screen as a woman with thick black hair shoved her way across the command centre. Her eyes were wild, her face contorted in rage. One arm was bandaged and her uniform was scorched and torn, “ *You! Give him back! Give them ALL back! Now! Or so help me I will fly out there, burn your ship and gut you to…”*

The security woman in the group, this one with silver highlights and a scar on her face, was trying to restrain the wild-woman. Catra cackled, “Wow, so this is how you negotiate? Threats? Alright, since we’re *escalating* .”

She gestured to her crew. The man at the weapons console nodded. They’d picked up a firing solution as Catra had spoken - at this range it was difficult, especially with the rocks, but they had a good line of sight.

A beam of coruscating green energy lanced out from the Destroyer’s main gun. It pierced the black as it streaked across the void and pierced the *Sea Gate’s* hull, where it was partly exposed - even with the cluster of asteroids, complete cover was impossible. There was silence, then explosions rippled through the near-derelict capital ship. Flames bubbled and blossomed as the vessel buckled and turned to slag as the cascade of destruction led to chain reactions throughout its hull. Catra watched, impassive and then nodded with satisfaction. She returned her gaze to the monitor , “Ten minutes. Then make a decision. Make this hard, I won’t *bother* boarding that rock.”

She cut the transmission and exhaled. Scorpia stood ramrod straight nearby, a faintly worried expression on her face, "Expertly done, ma'am. But, uh,.. You'd blow the station?"

Catra stalked back to her seat and slumped back down, "No. But we can *cripple* it. Look at the place - it's a *rock* . The amount of ordnance we'd have to pump into it to crack it? Insane. Miners use special tools to split 'roid's and that's *small* rocks. No, but the *threat* of a siege should make them think." She massaged her temples, "And the prisoner played his part admirably ."

"Ma'am?"

The feline chuckled humourlessly, "Yeah, of course he was going to blab. Credit to them, they've got loyalty . But now they've got something else to worry about - we have their people. And *maybe* we broke them. So, how *secure* are they really?" Catra cackled, a little forced, but she pushed it, "Spread the *fear* , make 'em overthink. When we board, we'll be able to take advantage of that. But first things first. Comms, order all vessels - launch drones, low emissions, advance to engagement range. Line ships to hold at intercept distance in case their shuttles run for it. Let the drones screen and take out their combat craft. We've got them ten to one, easily. Artillery ships to lock on their main facility, sensors to ID external arrays. They say *boo* we make 'em dark."

"Ma'am!" came the barked response and Catra smiled thinly . She forced herself to take a breath.

Your move, Adora. Don't make me kill you.

Please.

———————

"Well. That could have gone better," Glimmer smiled, but it was a little manic. Mermista was being restrained by Juliet, who was trying to calm the raging pirate captain. Adora's gaze was still fixed on the now-blank holo display.

Angella sighed and shook her head, her face creased with worry, "This is not good. They took out the *Sea Gate* with a single shot. We need to"…

"It was a derelict anyway , she's trying to intimidate us!" Glimmer exclaimed, "We need to rethink our defences, if Hawk blabbed or"…

"Dont you dare!" shrieked Mermista, "He would NOT! And he is *alive*! We need to get out there and *save* him!"

The voices were raised as the arguments escalated. Crew around the command centre began to look twitchy and anxious, a few eyeing the door and the possibility of escape.

"ENOUGH!" Adora's voice was a bark that brooked no argument, "This is what *she wants* . What the Horde *needs* . What Hawk may or

may not have said is irrelevant. We have a plan, we stick to it. They come at us differently when they board *and they will*, then we adapt. Keep the civilians safe, clear a path for the ships," Her grey-blue eyes fixed on all of them, in turn. Juliet looked poised to argue, but Adora raised a hand and stabbed a finger at the holographic display that now showed the Horde vessel formation, " *That's* what we need to be really worried about."

Angella blinked and looked at the display, "What?" Juliet stared at the display then made a *huh* noise.

"They arent in the normal configuration," she mused. Adora nodded.

"Two frigates and a support vessel - or artillery craft. Frigates for fighter screening and the long range ship to hit. That destroyer should have a pair of frigates too. But they've swapped the formation. She's put all her long range equipment in one area."

"A vulnerability?" mused Angella, but Adora shook her head.

"Bait, I reckon. Maybe one of a few plans. The frigate groups are now optimised for closer engagements and interception - they dont need to focused on protecting a vulnerable artillery ship. That destroyer has enough firepower to screen the artillery ships, at the cost of firing arcs. She has limited her long range to a single arc, but," Adora huffed, "to either tempt us to charge them which would be suicide. Or to force us to avoid that arc. Plus she can lay down

some long range damage. Those frigates will stop any ships escaping - they can spread out and screen."

"So, we surrender then? It sounds like she has us outflanked," Juliet practically growled the words out as she glared at the monitor. Adora shook her head.

"She's not following the rulebook, not exactly. But she won't be giving us ten minutes. Or rather, when those ten minutes are up, she'll pull the trigger," she sighed, "it's how she won all the time at the academy. Set the board up how she wanted. We'll have drones incoming, or fighters. Hell, maybe some shielded boarding vessels. We need to get the fighter screen out. And we need to get those frigates in…"

"What, why?" Angella coughed in shock, her face a mask of concern, "Get their firepower *closer* to the station?"

"That'll happen anyway," Adora said, distractedly as she studied the screen, "The big problems will happen if she deploys *manned* fighters. They can localise with the drones, so our disruption won't be as effective. So, we need to knock as *many* out as we can, create an opening, get as many people *out* as we can. And hope that the chaos stops her using those big guns."

The group shared a tense exchange of glances. Juliet nodded slowly, "So, sticking with the plan?"

Adora nodded curtly, then looked at Mermista, "You know we can't help him now."

The pirate captain glared at her, then looked away, "...cowards."

The blonde's lips tugged into a smile, "I said *we* can't help him. Not that no one could."

Mermista looked wrong-footed, "Wait, what?"

"We have some surprises. I expect Catra to have a few shocks back on that ship. Maybe not *enough* to stop it firing, but enough to make her cautious." Adora rubbed at her wrists and inhaled, "Ok, no time. We need to *launch* . Angella, I will keep the people safe as long as I can. But you need to get as many people *away* . I think Catra *wasn't* lying. She really will try to keep it as civil. But she's a local commander. If anyone higher up takes over? All guarantees are gone. She isn't that influential. She isn't as connected as she thinks or hopes she can be. No one in the Horde is. There is *always* someone bigger. So, you get as many people away as you can. Anyone who can't keep them secured, away from combat troops, clearly marked."

The base commander nodded curtly and fixed Adora with a hard stare, "Make them bleed."

The blonde met that cold gaze and nodded briefly, then headed out. She adjusted the chest rig and carefully lifted the mask that it was connected to - the painkiller setup from Bow and the others. She sighed and lifted the mask to her face, taking a deep draught of it. Immediately her body relaxed, but she could feel her senses dull a little. It kept the edge away, kept the nanites down - the faint electrical tingle across her skin reminded her that the monster was at bay for now.

She paused in the corridor beyond the command centre and leaned against the wall for a moment. Part of her still thought that, maybe, just maybe, if she left, took a ship and ran, the Horde would *go away*. But she knew the reality was murkier - this whole place was a problem. It wasn't *just* her. With a grunt she pushed off the wall and stalked down towards the hangar where the Horde fighter had been refueled and set aside. She requested it specifically - they needed it.

She passed soldiers as they ferried barricades and weapons. Worried civilians, fewer of them now, milled and tried to stay out of the way - several had already fled, cramming into shuttles and the odd refueling ship, heading for the void, risking the chance of running into Horde patrols. Adora hoped that they'd made it - Catra's fleet indicated the woman was more focused on the base than picking off stragglers.

A young soldier jogged up, her blast-helmet barely strapped on, "Ma'am. Chief Engineer Bow said you wanted, uh, these?"

The girl proffered a satchel, crammed with mining charges. Adora smiled grimly and nodded, "Thank you." She ignored the girl's flinch

as she took the bag - she knew she was a terrifying *thing* . But it still stung a little. She took a breath and smiled at the girl, "Stay safe, OK? Stick with your squad, watch out for each other . Nothing bad can happen as long as you look after each other, remember that."

The girl met her gaze and took a shallow breath, then nodded, "Yes ma'am." She threw up a sloppy salute, then dashed back into the throng. Adora hoped that the girl would survive this. Honestly, the chance of it *not* becoming a slug fest was slim, even with inside help or that tiny chance Catra could have been reasoned with. But the woman was being driven by *something* - the same thing that had always driven her, Adora suspected - power. Because with power came.what? Safety? Wealth? Respect?

They'd wanted all of it, back then, until Adora had had her moment of doubt. And Catra had…

Adora's fist hit the bulk-head of the corridor, the *clang* of the impact causing several troopers to pause in surprise. A muted chuckle startled Adora from her frustrated reverie.

"Save it for the Hordies, blondie."

The intimidating bulk of Huntara filled the corridor. The bounty-hunter-cum-pirate had her hands stuffed in the pockets of her leather jacket and a smirk was on her face as she approached Adora, sidestepping a scurrying soldier hauling a stack of rifles. Adora adjusted the satchel on her shoulder and took another drag from the

breather. Huntara arched an eyebrow and Adora shrugged, "Dont want to."…

"Go apeshit? Y eah, figured. So, Praetorian huh? Y ou know nothin's stays secret round here long. K inda feel better about you laying me out now. I mean, I *should* feel you cheated but." the woman winced, "I heard the stories."

"Save it," Adora sighed. Huntara shrugged.

"No pity , blondie. Fuckin' sucks. They tried sticking me with some *upgrades* too. It's why I bailed. That and, well.p ay was crap."

"Y ou got paid?" Adora snorted. Huntara grinned and barked a laugh, then slapped a hand onto Adora's shoulder. The blonde didn't even stumble.

"Y ou aint bad, you know that? So, apparently I'm your wingman. Y ou OK with me watching your back?"

"As long as you dont stare," Adora managed to smirk a little. That got another cackle from the big purple-skinned woman in front of her.

"Maybe some other time. Hey , I can make a j oke about endurance or some shit. So, we going drone-huntin'?"

Adora nodded and the pair fell into step as they headed towards the hangar. They emerged into a scene of barely controlled chaos. People rushed too and fro between hastily jury-rigged shuttles and combat-capable craft. Everything looked barely bolted on or ramshackle. Adora spotted the Horde fighter, dead centre. A few extra pods had been hastily attached, with wiring threaded into the guts of the machine - additional weapons or transmitters. Either way, they'd play hell with the handling. Adora sighed - it was necessary.

Huntara nodded to her, then jogged towards her own ship - a gunship, one of the few *actual* dedicated combat craft. It was big, boxy and looked lethal. The thing was a flying wedge of steel with turrets - a nightmare for drones. Having that on her wing would keep Adora pretty secure. But that wasn't a long term proposition for this engagement.

The blonde headed to her craft and clambered up the ladder to the cockpit, where she stowed the satchel of charges, before she clambered in herself. She adjusted her seat, then lifted the flight-helmet that had been provided by the base from the control console. She then fitted her breathing mask from the chest-rig to her face and slid the helmet over her hair. Immediately a HUD popped up, revealing holographic displays for the craft. She knew her body wanted to *directly* interface, but that would be a drain right now. Later.

Maybe.

"Comms check, Gold one online."

"Gold one, Command, we read you, over."

"Update on advance, over ."

"Confirm drone approach, have entered outer envelope of signal range. All stations quiet. Hold… command confirms deadline ends in sixty. Over."

"Roger . Clear for noise in sixty one, cut transmissions, confirm launch of first wave. Over."

"Received. Confirming with Command. Out."

Adora leaned back and heaved a breath. The board was set, their opening moves would be revealed. Then it was going to get messy. She closed her eyes and tried to relax, then reached up to pull the canopy of the fighter closed. She felt the reassuring pressure of a firearm bolted to the side of the cockpit interior - emergency use. Her bag of explosives added another card for her deck of tricks.

More blood, more violence. Necessary, yes. She wanted to avoid it. But it was inevitable. She inhaled again, letting the painkillers sooth her ravaged mind;letting the faint pulse of electricity keep the horror inside at bay. With a huff, she flicked the comms channel to a

different frequency and grinned mirthlessly to herself. She had a job to give to someone.

"Here. We. Go."

Chapter End Notes

I thought this would make for another tension builder - and it keeps it a similar length to the other chapters. Thank you for your patience, all!

Next chapter is.... going to be hard to get marshaled as a DT will happen. Such is the nature of combat.

Well see how it goes. Bit of a slower time as RL has hit me hard and my writing faltered, so this was me trying to regain. I hope you enjoy and don't mind me stringing this out a little bit more!

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Adora starts the fight.

Catra moves her pawns.

Bonnie throws a wrench in things.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Ma'am, time's up," Scorpia glanced at her Commander and shifted nervously, "Waiting on your command."

Catra eyed the back of her hand from her reclined position in the Captain's chair. She glanced at the various stations around the Destroyer's bridge and smirked mirthlessly, "Have we identified their communication arrays? Defences?"

One of the ensigns piped up, "Main comm tower is on the far side of the installation - several minor redundant arrays as well, ma'am. Entered into the targeting computer."

Another ensign chimed in, "Only point defence around the hangar identified. Catra sighed.

“And we want to keep the hangar mostly intact. No capital ships beyond the wreck?”

“None ma’am,” said the second ensign. She nodded in return, then looked to Scorpia.

“Fire a 40% strength beam, plus two salvos from the Artillery frigates - main station. Target the redundant arrays at least. Then activate the drones while they’re panicking.”

“Ma’am,” Scorpia saluted, then moved to the comms station, where she took a hold of a detachable microphone from a cradle. The officer stationed there nodded and Scorpia spoke, “All hands, prepare for combat. Artillery group, two volleys, targets being synced to your local targeting computers. Drone command, active in t-minus seventy seconds.”

Catra watched, her face set into a practiced grin as the screen displayed the main cannon firing. A bright, green beam lanced across the inky black and carved into the rock of the station. Alongside the Destroyer, the long, tube like artillery frigates fired - their frames shaking as their hyper-accelerated torpedoes launched out of the main railgun that made up the body of the vessels. They fired once, paused, then, as the main gun of the Destroyer ceased its firing cycle, they fired again.

On the distant rock, explosions blossomed as the hyper-fast torpedoes broke apart into multiple munitions to cause maximum

impact. In space the power of explosives were most effective against pressurised targets - for the concussive effect. A shockwave wouldn't travel easily across a vacuum - but when they hit a SOLID target, the effect was still impressive.

Of course, their target was a massive and dense rock, likely reinforced with metal and layers of armour. But it'd still rattle them. And maybe force Adora to play her hand.

A moment later, the drones activated. Indicators sprang up across the bridge as remote operators in the bowels of the destroyer and inside their distant frigates all chimed in to report the initiation of their attack. The drones would strip any point defences, any external arrays or sensors and clear a swathe for their dropships. Catra felt her jaw tighten as she watched. Her stomach felt coiled and nervous. She'd war gamed across from Adora so many times at the academy and usually ended up on top somehow. Oh yeah, in sparring, Adora had her beat two out of three times, unless Catra got *cunning* . But when it came to strategy, then Catra had the immediate upper hand. Adora was always reactive, trying to go for the sucker punch, the big assault. And that appealed to a certain *brand* of the Horde command. But Adora *also* was often cautious, not willing to risk troops. Which then negated that *appeal* .

Catra's more inventive approaches got attention but weren't quite doctrine, which got her sneered at, whilst also quietly acknowledged.

And she'd still ended up in a backwater .

Well, this time she was going to show them that throwing a wall of troops at a problem wasn't the way - you could escalate.

"Ma'am, we have an issue." The sensors officer spoke up. Catra gestured at him to go on, "Our readings around the enemy base have gone...dark? I mean we have remote visuals but I have zero signal noise that's discernable."

Catra sat up and frowned, then looked at the drone-command station, "Update me."

"Uh...we're...we're having trouble co-ordinating with the drones."

"Weaver, set all drones to automatic. Force the command. NOW."

"As you wish, Captain," sighed the AI. The drone command team looked perplexed, the man and woman turning to regard her. She stared back, taking in their pressed black and green uniforms, their neatly trimmed hair. They'd probably never seen a real live fire engagement. This was a backwater *logistics* patrol they'd been part of after all.

"They're jamming remote signals. It'll screw their own comms but...it means us trying to pilot the drones will have us lagging and delayed. So, better to let the bots run free. You *get* me? Keep monitoring. Weaver?

“ *Command sent. But the noise is dense. Order download is propagating across the swarm, but it’ll be thirty seconds for full upload.”*

“Eugh, time enough to wipe out enough. Scorpia have one frigate group move in, the other to move their units out to flank. Have the assault frigates adopt two rear, one front as an advance.”

“Ma’am.”

“And someone just…magnify the screen. It’ll be crap but we can see *something* . Laser sensors up, we can get a sketchy image at least? What is this, amateur hour? MOVE IT people. Scorpia, prep the manned fighters, if they’re not already . And the dropships?”

“On standby , ma’am.”

“Good…almost time then,” she smiled thinly . Scorpia adjusted uncomfortably.

“Are…you sure about this?” she adjusted her black command jacket nervously. Catra snorted.

“Lead from the front, yknow . I have full faith in your command capabilities.”

“Um, of course ma’am.”

Catra settled back in her chair and her grin was a little more genuine, “Well played Adora. Ready for what’s next?”

She had been expecting something like this, but the shaking of the station and the shrieks of the crew in the hanagar were still jarring. Catra was clearly going for the full psychological warfare angle. Adora chuckled, “Just like the old days,” she keyed her comm and just said, “Go time. Launch.”

One after the other, just over two dozen modified shuttles thrummed off the deck and blasted out of the hangar. It seemed an age since Adora had nearly torn this bay apart with Swiftwind. She noted the silos to one side; the empty racks where containers had stood - all now floating in the void outside. It felt sparse, nearly barren.

She watched Huntara’s gunship hovered off the ground, then took a breath before she initiated her craft’s own drive. The HUD and displays lit up to full and she pressed one of the foot pedals that controlled yaw, then gunned the throttle. She let herself be pushed back into the seat as she darted out through the seal-shield across the hangar bay.

The rock gave way to inky black, pebbled with rocks and metal. The shuttles had begun to spread out, and Adora grimaced as her IFF blossomed with red dots - Horde drones. She switched off her comm, which was all static. She had to trust initiative here.

She watched Huntara pull alongside briefly, then grinned as the bulky, blocky gunship rolled away with shocking grace. Muzzle flashes blossomed from its turrets and the main gun, followed the the smaller flashes of explosions as Drones were torn apart. Similar impacts were happening across the perimeter - the drones mostly confused as they waited for input orders.

Adora'd briefed the pilots - the collection of ships were a real mismash - commercial shuttles with a couple of tracer guns bolted on, or mining rigs with slow shot, high yield slug throwers. Targeting computers were a mix of mining scanners, laser trackers and some bootleg military grade stuff. But with the current jamming, most of this would be done with the mark one eyeball and the very basic display showing where the drones roughly were.

She'd told them to target the larger drones - they were signal relay points for the smaller ones. Drone pilots usually controlled around four simultaneously, with the other drones slaved to those four. Hit those and the smaller ones would then have to piggy back on the nearest *other* node or revert to individual local AI. Both of which were *poor* choices. Less combat ability or an increased signal load for a node-drone to manage, basically.

She wove between the slower shuttles, her eyes picking out distant targets easily. A few quick depresses on the flight stick trigger and

she watched three drone-nodes blossom into silent, fiery flowers. She angled her flight and skimmed over the surface of a container, noting the thrusters ready to go on it.

Another explosion drew her gaze and she grimaced: a shuttle tumbled by, engine trailing smoke, as a swarm of drones buzzed at it. They had no tactics, just chase and shoot - Catra must have ordered the switch - but the slow movement of the *other* drones showed it wasn't an instant success - they had time to thin the herd - and there had to be... Maybe a good couple hundred drones at least. She didn't want to count. They needed to make an impact or the amount of fire here would shred them.

She set to, moving and adjusting her flight path, stitching a pattern of destruction through the swarm - they were making a dent, albeit slowly.

Then another massive explosion shook the base, as the Destroyer fired again, with more artillery blasts - this time, closer to the hangar bay - clearly they were now attempting to cut off escape - to ensure no transports could leave *and* to stop their combat craft from landing to resupply or patch repair.

Well that wasn't going to happen - Adora spun her craft back to the containers and, as she got close, triggered a signal. Several of the blocky storage units began to move, forming a haphazard screen - it'd not last against the destroyer 's beam for long, but it would stop those torpedoes.

One of the smaller asteroids likewise began to move, forming another blocker, closer to the station. They'd fitted a few of them with smaller thrusters from the Sea Gate. Among *other* things.

The beam fired again, clearly weaker this time, having had no time to charge - it splashed against the containers and melted through, but then just headed the rocky slag within. The container barely moved, just floated, now slightly warped- the beam having no real *concussive* force. And since the container was just metal and dense, mostly melted rock *anyway* it was hideously ineffective. Nothing to shear off, no components to fry, nothing explosive to trigger .

The torpedoes had *more* of an effect, but again,whilst it pulverised a container, all it really did was create a screen of debris. Of course, the Horde *ground* tactic was to absolutely rain artillery and then advanced across the churned ground. They tried a similar doctrine in space - but *again* artillery works well against a specific target - soft, mostly, easily disrupted.

Bombard a mountain and you wreck roads. But if you're trying to get a mountain to give up.. .all you do is rearrange its scenery a bit and make your own advance more difficult.

Adora knew that wasn't the main thrust - this was shock and awe - meant to scare, to force them to be defensive. So where was the actual.ah *ha* .

She was flying at full tilt, keeping ahead of the slowly adapting drones, still picking away at them;but she was looking around the space around her constantly. She saw the three frigates closing in from below - sacrificing a full screen for escaping ships to hope to entrap them closer to the wall, as it were. Again, not normal approach either - normally it was two to the fore, one in the rear. Catra had inverted it, making for a tempting target, covered by a much nastier rear guard.

She could see the impact already - nearby drones began to react and suddenly became *lethal* . She watched two shuttle bank away, having spotted the encroaching frigates - twenty five drones poured after them in pursuit. One shuttle pinwheeled away, in flames, while the other managed to jnk between floating rocks to evade.

Adora hit her thrusters, then cut the engine, spinning her craft on its axis. She then fired three six-second blasts from her guns into the flank of the pursuing swarm, not caring to pick targets. Drones spun away, damaged or destroyed as she accelerated down. Ahread, the frigate spotted her and tracer fire began, so dense that it almost looked like a beam. She disengaged her rig for a moment and let her Praetorian reactions kick in for mere seconds. Her wrist twitched and her craft gracefully arced and barreled around the fire, before she skimmed over the top-most surface of the frigate. It continued up, almost more aggressively, as the two rear frigates tried to get a bead - she jnked, keeping the fore-frigate behind her , to muddy their easy-tracking, then she was past them, turning again. Several drones were in pursuit and more broke of from the swarm to track her. A DOT more.

She had been recognised.

Adora cursed, but she knew it was very very inevitable. Of course, while they were focusing on *her* they weren't focusing on the cargo containers…

"Ma'am, suspect Praetorian craft identified," yammered the sensor officer. Catra sat up a little straighter.

"Highlight," she barked.

Their more limited sensors had managed to portray a limited wire-frame of the battle, coupled with the zoomed in visual they had on screen. They had a large blob to symbolise the drones, which were taking a beating; several red arrows to show the enemy craft; and Blue diamonds for the frigates. One red triangle was further from the others and had an "MP" next to it.

"We can't ID it - IFF is struggling at this range."

"But the drones aren't targeting it?" mused Catra.

"Captain Cobalt has informed us he is manually targeting the ship, ma'am, and has instructed his crew to disable it."

"Kill her . Kill her . Kill her!"

Weaver's sudden declaration shocked the crew. Catra stared up at the speaker, "What?"

"She is a class ten biohazard - if she has not destroyed their base then she is either operating independently - which is impossible or she is following orders. Those orders may be from a rival faction within the Horde hierarchy and either way she is a legitimate threat to our operations!"

Catra blinked, "She's afraid of her," she breathed, "you're afraid of her… really afraid."

" *You should be terrified, Captain. You know what she wants. She is a priority target. Leaving her alive merely gives her the opportunity to cause further issues."*

"Ma'am!" the sensor ensign looked shocked, "One of the frigates has reported a hull breach."

" *She is a threat!"* Weaver hissed. The Ensign shook her head.

"Uh no..ma'am? Should I call her..ma'am, ma'am? I mean, um, Commander, Captain, she uh..the praetorian didn't do anything, her vessel is engaging the drones. It looks like one of the containers..accelerated into the frigate' s flank and detonated. Or… um..ejected its cargo at close range..explosively ."

Catra whistled slowly, "Improvised minefield. Artillery frigates, reprioritise those containers, ok Scorpia? They'll be a problem for larger ships advancing. Hit them enough and you'll knock out their thrusters. Oh and have our other two frigates move up to support - their guns should be able to knock out any more improvised booby-traps."

"Reports of heavy gunfire from.. An asteroid?" reported the sensor officer again, frowning. Catra blinked and grimaced.

"They stripped the capital ship. Of course. Crap. Which asteroids?"

"Not sure, ma'am. W e need the sensor jamming down."

Catra nodded slowly, then stood, "Scorpia, you have the bridge. I'm taking the drops ships and commanding the fighter crews from the fore. We'll get you visuals, then knock out any big-guns you see, ok?"

"Ma'am," Scorpia saluted and Catra returned it with a grin. The big Scorponi coughed, "Be careful, Wildcat."

"Whaaat? I always am," snorted Catra and she pivoted and left the bridge, jacket billowing behind her.

Adora was pleased - that had gone better than expected. The Container trap had worked and one frigate was now heavily damaged along a flank - not crippled, but it wouldn't be as mobile. The other two frigates had moved into a defensive posture and forced a drone swarm to provide cover. Which just meant Adora was content to dive in and strafe, whilst angling away from the return fire. She led any pursuers on a swift dance through the debris field, before she then returned to strafe again, either leaving Huntara to pick off the drones behind her, or letting them join the fray unfolding around the base.

She had no idea how the fight was going overall - this was all to bide time, draw the enemy's focus. She trusted Angella and the others to know when the moment was right - when the drones and frigates were fully engaged. She'd hoped Catra would commit more, but that had been an idle hope - the woman *was* rash. But not if she was prepared. In the moment she could be goaded, but if she had a position of strength, that was harder to rattle.

But things were tight - the proximity of the frigates meant that more drones were being brought back into the network. And the cloud of debris that was slowly expanding was making it harder for the rebel pilots to fly - a drone could bounce and shrug off an impact, but an

organic crew could lose control. Which meant the fight was slowly, ever so slowly, spreading out.

She needed to cause more chaos. But as she was about to commit, she saw two of their prepped cannon emplacements open up. They'd setup four - two of which were, unfortunately , easier to hit from the artillery group's angle. But these two had a whole asteroid between them. But *not* between them and the frigates. The heavy guns blasted a salve into the crippled frigate, which shook under the impact. Armour tore away and the main engine guttered and died.

The other twio ships immediately rolled to present their more armoured flanks and switched their fire from the dogfight *above* to the guns *below* . Another salvo punched up and tore one turret away from a second frigate, with more minor impacts slamming into the shield and armour. The ship rolled, damaged, but in fighting shape. The other frigate took a hit to the command towers and began to pitch - the bridge having been damaged, clearly. It slowly came under control, albeit sluggishly.

As one, the two frigates launched a salvo of missiles and one of the big-guns vanishes in a cascade of blue flame, the asteroid shaking as a dozen warheads hit. The exposed generator and the stored ordnance went up, creating a mini sun for a minor second.

Adora hissed, after taking down another three drones, before she pivoted into a dive.

More chaos was needed.

She tapped the command computer on her flight screen and then deactivated her chest rig. The Praetorian reached out and she reached for the navigation computer, rapidly typing out a command into it, well beyond its usual, expected command chain. An override code and she inhaled, deeply, before she checked that her helmet was sealed. Then she unhooked their flight belt and popped the canopy of the fighter.

The ship was on a dive, straight for the most damaged frigate. Drones warmed up to meet her, but the fighter spun through them before pulling a shocking turn. Adora…

Leapt.

She drifted across the void as her fighter suddenly shrieked away into the black, drones following it. She drifted down, towards the surface of the frigate, rifle in one hand, satchel of mining explosives in the other. Her feet settled against the deck plating with a dull *thunk* that she heard through her bones.

Adora looked "up" at the battle - tracer fire and distant dots, all exploding in beautiful colours. The main abse loomed large, covered in new craters and ragged blast marks - still standing. She smiled as she saw a second hangar door open, on the far side, away from the artillery units. Small freighter ships streamed out, half a dozen, making good speed towards another cluster of asteroids. She could

see the second frigate group were not best placed to intercept - they'd spread the wrong way , assuming that *this* frigate group would be able to block an escape.

Plus they'd left a few containers in that area as well.some empty , some booby trapped - but the Horde wouldn't know if they *were* or not, so would likely be a bit more careful, if they'd observe proceedings so far.

She turned back to the fight, content the first wave were away - she'd also seen some of their own shuttles moving to screen, so even if the frigates tried to move in, they'd be distracted.

Slowly, deliberately, Adora clomped over the hull of the damaged Frigate, towards one of the still-firing turrets. She has the rifle slung over her back, where it bobbed in the zero-gravity of space.With care, she clamped the heavy mining explosive to the surface of the gun, just above the rim where it rotated over the hull. Then she moved on, down the hull, towards the next turret.

It was slow going and, thanks to the bridge being damaged, she was fairly sure that the surface sensors were not being as effectively monitored.

That hope was dashed when a drone swung by and began to come about, clearly looking to investigate. Adora unslung her rifle and fired. The round sheered away from the drones heavy around - of

course, it was rated for deep space and this..this was an atmospheric blaster rated against *body armour* .

Adora rolled her eyes as the combat drone accelerate and began to fire. Adora scrambled and managed to push off the hull towards the next turret. Metal sparked behind her and she grunted in pain as she hit the turret *hard* . The drone was still coming, so Adora fished out another explosive and threw it across the void. As it tumbled with shocking speed, she brought up the rifle and fired as the drone tried to angle a shot that *wouln't* damage the turret. A moment later, the mining charged detonated as Adora's shot hit true and the drone vanished in a cloud of scrap.

That trick wouldnt work if there was a *swarm* however. Adora managed to grab the base of the turret and re-magnetised her boots. She applied another charge, then another, before she moved to the third turret. Then she moved slowly up the command tower to the damaged bridge. The blast shields were down, but the hull was dented, badly. She could see small wisps of venting atmosphere that ceased to spray white ether as people inside sealed them. She felt a pang of guilt, but then swallowed it and stoically planted the last couple of charges against the sealed blast-shield.

Then she knocked on the blast shield. She could see a couple of remote sensors - cameras for external surveying,. Most ships didnt have them on - as combat was conducted over hundreds of kilometers, these things were for purely maintenance use *most* of the time. She saw one had been blown apart by the main cannon strike, but the other looked to be angling. Her way.

She watched as it focused on her. Then she waved, pointed at the fastened charge and then *launched* herself away from the surface of the frigate. She gave a count of ten, then depressed the button on the remote trigger she had tied to her belt.

It was eerie, watching an explosion in the silence of space. Those charges were mean to crack rock at fissure points - shaped charges, they focused all that pressure in a very specific way. Which was also why they were very good against *armour* .

The turrets of the frigate were practically blown off as the charge triggered the ordnance inside, cooking the ammunition and sending shockwaves through the ship. The vessel listed again under those. The bridge blossomed as the top of the command tower was split open. A blast of atmosphere expanded out in a short lived bubble of flame that guttered in the vacuum. The ship drifted, crippled, out of the fight.

Adora turned and tried to push away the thought of the lives she'd just taken. She adjusted her flight suits rudimentary thrusters and angled towards the base it was far off - a good few dozen kilometers, just under , perhaps.

A flashed of engines drew her attention and she grinned as Huntara's gunship banked and spun, to match her speed. A hatch opened and a merc leaned out grabbing for her. Adora allowed herself to be reeled in and laughed as the gunship accelerated. She saw the drones of the defensive swarm fighting off a few shuttles that were doing hit and runs, while the remaining two, damaged frigates fended away the fire from the main-gun. She grimaced as,

with a flash of several heavy impacts, the asteroid the gun sat on was split asunder - the artillery group clearly having been keyed onto its location. No green beam though - so maybe her fighter had done its job?

But the main objective had been completed - the frigates were not a *mobile* thread, or at least that group weren't.

Adora moved through the gunship nodding her thanks to the merc. She moved to the cockpit and leaned against Huntara's chair, "Thanks," she managed through her helmet, the mic transmitting at close range. The big merc grunted.

"Not over yet. Look there."

Adora followed her gesturing hand and groaned. She stared at Huntara's scanner - which was now showing things a LOT more clearly - the jammer had clearly been diminished by the Frigate's signal boosting. Right now it was showing that a flight of manned fighters had just entered the fray, carving a path through the melee, chasing off the shuttles and locking them into a deadlier dogfight. And following behind them?

Heavily armoured and armed troop transports.

They had enough jamming to ensure the drones had to cluster if the Horde wanted to control them effectively, but with this number of

Horde ships in proximity, disrupting their comms would be much harder. At least *that* way.

She hoped the base, with the codes she'd given them, would be able to sow confusion, but that would only work temporarily. They needed more time to get people away. She could tell that another wave of evacuees had left, the distance of the ships from the base likely meaning they'd gone as soon as she'd blown the frigate.

She grimaced, "Get close to the base. I'm going in hot."

"Aye aye Caph," chuckled Huntara, "Anyone ever tell you you're nuts?"

"Oh...one person," Adora smiled as the fond memory drifted through her head. She didn't let it sour as she normally did, but just sighed, "Let's do this."

Scorpia leaned forwards in the Captain's chair, face pensive as she rested her chin against her pincers. She watched the display intently and grimaced as she watched the battle unfolding. Catra was boarding one of the transports in the hangar bay and Scorpia felt it was, perhaps, a bit of a risky idea. This whole thing felt too messy for a *Lead Commander* to get too close to.

She watched the frigates managed to take out one turret at least. She gestured to the gunnery station, "Target the second position, inform the artillery frigates. Need to make sure the transports arent knocked out. Sensors, any further movement? More gun emplacements?"

"Small arms only - seems they've got point defence positions on some of the smaller rocks - those are messing up more of the drones. But manned fighter craft should be able to react better to them."

"Good, good," mumbled Scorpia. She nodded as the flight control officer turned her way.

"Ma'am, boarding teams are away . Fighter escort is moving ahead. We have an inbound Horde fighter though. Strange, we havent launched any until"…

The ship *lurched* and Weaver spoke, her voice rigid and harsh: "*Incoming vessel. Warning! Incoming vessel!"*

On the screen, the green beam of the main gun lanced out, aiming right at the incoming fighter. The small ship danced easily around the beam and Scorpia had the weirdest sense of deja vu, when that Hawk-guy had tried the same. Except this ship wasnt pulling up - it was on a collision course. She watched as a flurry of small-yield missiles were highlighted on the rudimentary hologram - the fighter had just launched antifighter missiles at them?

"What the h"…

And then the craft accelerated further. The gunnery officer yelled that they'd lost control of point defence. Scorpia glowered and yelled, "W eaver! Y ou are out of line!"

"She must be stopped! She must not get aboard! I will not allow it!"

Scorpia growled and flipped open a panel on the Captain's chair - a button that Entrapta had installed sat there, similar to the one they'd had on the *Shadow* , "Last warning!"

"She must be sto-" Scorpia hit the button and Weaver fell silent. The station lights all flickered and then the crewmen began reporting in their access had been restored. A moment later the ship shook and the gunnery officer groaned.

"Ma'am… impact on the main cannon array . Damage unknown but… system reports say the weapon cannot fire without catastrophic output."

"Damnit." Scorpia huf fed, then looked around the room, "Alright. Any escape pods? Ejections? If that was the Praetorian, we best be gosh darn ready, ok?"

"Y esh!" chorused the troops. And then the lights flickered. One tech frowned and turned around, "Power surges reported near engineering, ma'am. Could be feedback from the damage"?

"Get a team down there to investigate," Scorpia leaned back in the chair and groaned - Catra was going to have a fit - she'd had to lock down Weaver and now their Destroyer had reduced effectiveness. Well, they had numbers at least. She just hoped it was enough.

Of course, when ten minutes later someone told her that there was gunfire reported in the hangar, she almost actually cursed.

Bonnie pressed up against the bulkhead and waited. She watched from her hiding spot as Catra headed with purpose towards the hangars. She had Rogelio in tow, clearly ordered to accompany her, along with several other pilots. The dreadlocked girl exhaled with relief as Catra passed by without spotting her. She stole down another corridor before she reached the elevators, then headed towards the brig. She'd been in the hanagar to make preparations - Rogelio being dragooned to be Catra's pilot threw a spanner into things but it couldn't be helped.

She wasn't sure how things were going in the fight outside - a few cursory comments had said the rebels seemed more prepared and, given that they had a freaking *Praetorian* on side, she wasn't

shocked. Adora's vague threat still hung in her head - the *sadness* and *determination* with which it was given just chilled her .

She entered the brig and nodded to the guard on duty at the desk, before she looked up at the camera. She hoped like hell Adora's little disruption trick would work - she was pretty sure the woman had done something - Weaver hadn't acknowledged her at all, even when she'd asked some direct questions. *When* Adora had done it, that she had no idea about - when they'd contacted her? When she'd disabled access on the Frigate? Connie didn't know and it scared her more.

But right now she had her part to play. She felt guilty as sin, but if it helped keep Kyle safe, maybe just saved some lives? She could live with that. She looked to the guard and coughed, "Uh, here to transfer the prisoners to the hangar bay."

"I wasn't informed," grumbled the guard. He glared up at her , frustrated. Connie shrugged and rolled her eyes, before she presented a data slate to him. She'd managed to forge the signature on it, Again, without Weaver's interference that had been easy - just a case of moving some files around. The man studied the slate, then sighed. He reached for a comm link, clearly about to confirm something when the ship *lurched* . Weaver's voice came over the tannoy " *Incoming vessel. Warning! Incoming vessel!"*

The man cursed and thrust the data pad back at Connie, "Get a move on then, there's that singing idiot and four others. Just you? Where's the escort detail?"

"All hands on, we're in a fight man! Plus they're shackled and I'm armed. Unless you want to come with?"

He sighed and nodded, "Protocol," she smiled and nodded, then watched as he depowered the cells and ushered the beaten looking captives out. Hawk shot Bonnie a strange look, then arched an eyebrow. She nodded slowly and unhooked the stun rod at her belt, then glanced to the guard as he shoved the slower prisoners forwards.

Hawk sagged, then lurched forwards and shoved Bonnie. A moment later, the baton was in his hands and then he had it pressed to the throat of the guard. The man spasmed, then fell unconscious. The prisoners let out a whoop, which Hawk shushed as he fished the security fob from the unconscious guard. "Friends, I am always for reverie but now calls for *stealth* and *subtlety.* And Stars knows I need All the help I can get keeping this fantasticness in check! Now… put him away while we decide what to do with her…"

"Knock her out? Cut her throat?" mumbled one prisoner . The others seemed enthused by that idea, but Bonnie just straightened and glared at them.

"Real nice way to treat someone bustin' your sorry asses out. Not sure *Adora* 'd appreciate that level of gratitude."

Hawk paused and cocked his head, before he continued to unfasten the prisoners shackles with the fob, "You're a rebel spy?"

"Psh, hardly . But right now, our interests align. Someone I care about is at risk. Freeing you might be able to limit the damage he's at risk at. This ship could cause problems, so it needs to be temporarily removed from the eqation."

"Only temporarily?" Hawk smiled widely . Bonnie glared.

"No killing. Y ou all need to get to the hangar - best way to distract this thing - jailbreak."

"I think we can make a detour first." Hawk waggled his eyebrows and Bonnie glared. But somehow she still found herself following the ragtag group as Hawk searched down the corridors. They were relatively close to engineering here, or at least some access parts. Bonnie frowned at the man.

"What the hell are you playin' at?"

"When I was but a wee lad, I worked maintenance in a Horde shipyard - learned my trade about ships and my fascination with them there! Of course, not exactly *amazing* at shipwrighting. Never could get the welds right. But I do know how these things are built. And how they can be broken."

He clambered into a maintenance tube. A moment later the lights flickered. Red emergency lighting came on and sirens began to wail. Bonnie stared into the tube as Hawk slid out. His hair was smoking

gently and his mustache looked…crispy… She shook her head, "The hell did you do?"

"Ah, some…minor rewiring. Also an electrical fire. Entirely intentional! And, well…looks like the main gun got impacted by something! Someone stole my idea! But I also disrupted a few systems - nothing major, but they'll have to get some workarounds in place as I *may* have caused a surge here or there. So. Hangar bay?"

The corridors were fairly empty, with most crew being on station already. They did meet one or two, but the prisoners managed to overpower them as the crew clearly didn't expect hostels on board. Bonnie managed to stop any overt violence, of course, but let the prisoners help themselves to the sidearms of the downed crew. The bay itself, however, was a hive of activity - most of the troop transports were gone, along with all the fighters. But a couple of blocky Horde gunships stood at the ready. Bonnie sighed and gestured to them, "You need to make this look good."

The prisoners exchanged glances, then nodded. Hawk squatted down next to a stack of crates, resting his arms against their tops. He took a deep breath, then sighted down his purloined pistol and fired.

Across the hangar, a fuel barrel flashed, then erupted into a mushroom of flame. It didn't explode, rather it just gushed out sputtering, sparking fire. The crew, shocked by the sudden blast of a firearm, were then distracted by the flaming barrel, which began to roll across the deck, leaving a trail of burning fuel behind it. Crew yelled and shrieked, dashing to grab fire suppressant supplies. Strangely, the auto fire suppressors *weren't* triggering. Bonnie

assumed either her weird Weaver block OR Hawk's meddling were responsible.

She watched the prisoners as they sprinted for the gunships. Some of the crew rallied and a few began to charge the prisoners, only to dive for cover as the escapees opened fire. Bonnie took that moment to unholster her own pistol and fire at the escapees, albeit aiming wide. She yelled out "We've been boarded!" which sent the hangar crew into more panic as they looked around for other assailants.

The escapees returned the favour and fired back at her, deliberately missing. Luckily , most of the hangar crew were technicians - no marines down here right know - but that would change. Bonnie turned and shot the door controls, sealing this entrance to the hangar. That would prevent reinforcements for a moment at least. She turned around to find Hawk standing in front of her. He smiled at her apologetically, "Thanks for the assist, but I do think it best you come with us!"

Before she could react, he punched her, hard, in the stomach, then hoisted her over his shoulder. She wheezed as the man sprinted across the bay and clambered aboard one of the gunships. The other one had already lifted off and was turning, while small arms fire pinged off its armour.

Bonnie watched, dazed as the prisoners clambered into the gunship's stations and then shuddered as the second craft came to life, engines roaring with blue energy as it hovered off the deck plates. Turrets turned and Bonnie inhaled, sure that hell was about to be unleashed. But instead of gunning down the Horde troops, the

turrets just strafed the other docked craft, blasting one transport to pieces, whilst the other gunship tore apart the refueling bank. Then the pair of ships accelerated out of the hangar bay, the doors of which had *not* closed. Bonnie slumped against the bulkhead, suddenly shaky and drained. She Squeezed her eyes shut, realising that she'd left Rogelio behind, all alone. All her fault.

Because she'd actually done it.

She'd turned traitor.

She hoped it was worth it.

Chapter End Notes

WOOO! One more chapter to goooo.

Thank you for your patience everyone - as you can see... it's getting BUSY.

Everyone's getting to have a moment!

Also, is Weaver worried or something? NAAAH.

Let me know what you think!

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

The final scramble.

Catra delivers the coup de grace.

What complex beings we are.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Entering the debris field ma'am, comms still online," the dropship pilot spoke over his shoulder. Catra nodded at the woman, her eyes fixed on the vista before her. The ship rattled as micro-shrapnel skimmed across its surface.

It was chaos, to put it bluntly - the widely spaced asteroid field now a mess of shredded metal and rock. Wrecked drones, scuttled rebel-shuttles and floating, high velocity rocks from those IEDs. She admired the ingenuity there - jungle warfare ambush tactics translated to space combat. Adora's plan, no doubt.

She tilted her chin at the console, "Report from the fleet?"

"Commander Scorpia has updated - infiltration on the destroyer. Prisoner escape and..." the pilot winced, "Patching it to your tablet ma'am."

Catra sighed and looked down at the data tablet in her free hand. Her frown wasn't a scowl, though: sometimes it disappointed her when she was right. She looked back at the pilot, "Open a channel to the Destroyer."

"Ma'am."

The cockpit was cramped, with a pilot, co-pilot and a comms officer. The comms chair was sat to the rear of the pilots, at a 90 degree angle. The officer on station handed her a spare headset and Catra nodded to the man, "Commander , sitrep."

"Ah, Captain, report main gun offline. Rogue fighter impacted it. Will take an hour to repair. Minor electrical sabotage and a prisoner escape. Also, I had to engage Weaver's shackles."

"From the top, Commander ," Catra ground her teeth and sighed, "Bonnie, right?"

"Ah… how…"

"Always plan for the worst, expect the best. Which gunships did they take?"

"Ah… two of them?"

"Good. W e can track them. Did she escape with them?"

"Well, reports say they… kidnapped her? But the brig duty sergeant says she reported to escort them…"

"Y eah, I bet she did. No idea how she got compromised…maybe thought she could get free. Alright, why the shackles?"

" *Weaver attempted to take control of the vessel to shoot down a single fighter."*

"The same fighter that took out the gun?"

"The same, ma'am. But, uh, our point defence was already attempting to track and… she thought it was the Praetorian."

"Alright, you did the right thing there Scorpia.I have a feeling if she had full control she may have..T ried something," Catra sighed. Having the main gun offline wasnt ideal;but then again she didnt like the idea of Weaver taking an opportunity to "accidentally" fire the damn thing at her dropship. They had her locked down tight, but had had to give her *some* leeway to operate across a fleet. And the AI was cunning, able to lie and obscure its intent well enough.

How she wished she'd brought Entrapta along for this assault. But the woman seemed close to a breakthrough with that weird cargo mech. The damn thing creeped her out.

That thought made her glance back into the main troop bay behind her, visible through the cockpit hatch. A black case sat in the cargo netting, among the ammo crates and equipment boxes. She shivered, unsure why she was bringing it. Catra forced herself to look ahead.

"Alright, keep a track of the gunships. I imagine that they'll rip out the main IFF trackers..but they don't know about the *extras* ."

Since Adora had stolen that fighter, Catra had ordered the Engineers to equip *secondary* IFF devices to each ship. In case someone tried that trick a second time. The turnaround had been quick, given they'd mobilise *this* force so fast. Catra heaved a sigh and watched as their fighter escort began to pull ahead into the field. In the distance she could make out the distant flashes as their drones continued to battle with the beleaguered rebel space craft.

"*Ma'am, you don't want us to pursue?"*

"No, they can lead us to the *next* hiding spot. I think they've managed to evacuate a fair amount from the station. Always leave an enemy an escape unless you want to be fighting a desperate opponent. But also know *where* they're gonna be running to." Her smile was humourless. She knew one of the frigate screens wouldn't

be enough to cover all avenues - she'd put two out there, but still - space was BIG. She huffed, "Status of our frigates?"

" *The Rapier is crippled, but reporting only five fatalities, several non-lethal casualties. The Sabre Is operational, but only at 25% effectiveness. Bridge was compromised, main guns offline. Torpedo tubes functional, Point defence still operational, but they're having to command from engineering and the sensor suit. Two fatalities, only one from the bridge though… seems, uh… they got boarded and… "*

Catra sighed, "Let me guess? Adora?"

"Uh, if what they've reported is true… no visual data. Single EVA assault. But she gave them… time to get out?"

That made Catra frown. Adora was pulling punches? Again, something clenched at her, but she pushed it down, "Understood. Fighter contingent should have the space cleared and we will have superiority. Boarding will commence shortly. Maintain a cordon, get that main gun fixed. Artillery frigates to remain of overwatch, frigate cordon to *disable* larger ships if possible, but to *not* pursue. Dont need any more traps."

As if on cue, the sensor on the command console blipped and Catra saw several larger freighter signatures appear from within the massive asteroid base. The second group of frigates moved to engage, but the distance was likely too far.

“ *As ordered, ma’am.”*

“Excellent. Keep me appraised. Boarding team Alpha, out.”

She removed the headset and handed it back to the comms officer, then watched the sensor as one of the freighters seemed to slow. She glanced back at the communications station and the officer nodded, then looked at her, “Frigate *Voulge* reports success torpedo strike on target engines. They cannot intercept the other ships - they are moving at full burn into the field.”

“Not pursuing? Good. Seems people can follow orders,” Catra snorted. She nodded ahead, “Order the fighters to engage, sweep the field. Target any energy signatures.”

“Secondary frigate group reports contact with capital level guns. They are unable to intercept,” reported the comms officer and Catra watched as another group of signatures exited the base, “Frigates reporting effective fire on the enemy gun emplacements. One neutralised, moving to engage the second. They have identified a further set of cargo containers between them and the likely flight paths.”

Catra nodded - her people were learning. So far, their casualties were low, limited to drones and the crippling of two ships.

Ahead, the fighters had reached the skirmish. The change was beautiful to behold: the drones, flying as single, independent units, suddenly shifted and synched. Clusters formed around each Horde fighter as the blade-like fighters roared through the void, becoming miniature wingmen.

Where before each drone had been operating on its own limited intelligence, just chasing targets of opportunity, listing threat parameters, now they were co-operating with organic pilots and the more advanced fighter computer systems. Each fighter went from a single, deadly ship, to a single deadly ship with floating turrets around them.

It reminded Catra of those vids she and Adora had stolen one night, showing animals and beasts from some aquatic world - fishes, she remembered. Small ones that ahd drifted alongside the silent predators, clustering about them.

And just like those predators did to their prey, the rebels scattered; their disorganised formations suddenly becoming panicked evasions as the trained Horde pilots dove into them, weaving between wrecked containers and spiraling rock. Catra saw a flash in the distance as another, then another of the remaining rebel fighters were snuffed out.

"Dont target the escape pods. If their ships have any. More prisoners, more intel."

"By your command, ma'am."

"First wave of dropships, begin approach to the nearest hanger; secondary strike teams identify external airlocks, prepare to breach. We want to overwhelm from multiple entry points. They'll be trying to use the furthest docking bay to evacuate. Do not approach: they'll likely have active defences there."

The comms officer nodded, then relayed the orders. Catra's grip tightened on the handle above her. The final act.

Rogelio felt uncomfortable. Not physically: being in the cockpit of his fighter felt *natural* . But instead, he had the gnawing sense of unease. Bonnie's plan had felt desperate, but he understood the *why* of it. He had to go along with it - to report her would have been to betray his love, his devotion, even if she didn't quite know it. And also, it would perhaps save his other soul from death: Kyle, trapped, far across this empty void.

His people had been hauled from their desert world many years before, by an Empire that saw their utility as soldiers;saw their resilience as *useful* . Rogelio had always served, as had all his clutch-mates. But he hadn't *belonged* until Bonnie and Kyle had entered his life.

But this whole endeavour troubled him.

They had mutinied once before, against Catra: back when she had been a tyrant. An eqitable situation had been reached - Catra affording them leeway, them not being spaced, her not dying to a resentful crew. And, to her credit, she had mellowed. This new situation hadnt *quite* changed the woman, but her ambition as clear. And still she had seen them forward, well enough.

But things were spiralling. He didnt know what bnnie planned. When it had just been them aboard the Shadow , it had been *fine* . The frontier of space, free in all but name. And then that ship had turned all of this on its head. Catra seemed to be on a mission of her own, their little sense of rebellion and freedom snuffed out as the Horde reasserted itself over them.

He felt conflicted. Not a good place to be.

Ahead, his HUD tracked possible routes through the debris. The crackle of orders in his ear instructed his wing to advance, to clear a path for the dropships. He rumbled a response, then reached forward to flick comms to his wingmen. His guttural voice was picked up by the translation software and conveyed in a smooth, clear voice: *“All fighters, maintain formation, burn to three quarters, eyes forward for targets. Set drone pairing to active.”*

The fighters streaked forwards and Rogelio saw the skirmish ahead - drones weaving about between rocks and jagged metal: the hulk of

the destroyed enemy capital ship hung like the corpse of some space leviathan in the background, whilst spiralling rocks and metal bounced around the gravity well.

His sensor pinged another craft at the periphery: a gunship that looked to be heading for the docking bay of the vast asteroid station; except it pivoted away after doing a pass in front of the shielded bay , angling away from the battle: retreating. Rogelio felt his fingers clench - they were abandoning their allies.

The thought felt somewhat hollow, considering his own actions. He steeled his thoughts, and pulled his fighter into a roll between two large slabs of wrecked cargo-container, diving into the melee. His computer pinged as several drones paired to him and his hud indicated he now had a full compliment of augmented weaponry.

Ahead, a box shuttle was weaving between rocks, chasing another drone. Rogelio flicked his comm again, “ *Weapons free, pick targets and engage.”*

He dove after the shuttle, the g-forces pushing him into the padded seat of the fighter. Rock and metal zipped past the canopy as he settled into a pursuit, his computer painting the target to track. The shuttle must have realised he was tailing it as it broke off its own pursuit to try to shake him among the rocks. The pilot seemed familiar with navigating a dense asteroid thicket, but they didnt have Rogelio’s practiced skill at combat manoeuvres.

He used his sensors to track the shuttle's position and banked right, rather than pursuing it through a denser patch of rock. Instead he pivoted his craft, allowing the momentum to take him parallel. He cleared the large rock and saw the shuttle still evading, assuming he was behind it.

The enemy had no time to react: Rogelio flicked the tricker on the flight stick and his craft rumbled as the autogun spat forth death. Alongside him, the drones fired as well. The shuttle tried to roll, but the tracer fire just tore along its flank, gutting the ship. The drone fire finished it off, sending the enemy ship pinwheeling away, venting flame and atmosphere.

Rogelio growled and rengaged his main drive, sending his craft forwards again, his sensors picking out the next target: only a bare dozen enemies left it seemed, if that. One by one he coils see them winking out as his wingmen picked them off.

It felt like overkill: the shuttle had looked like some sort of civilian model with weapons grafted to it in haste. Probably enough to take out an auto-drone, but a military fighter?

Not a challenge.

He checked his scanner again and noticed the drops ships splitting up, their boxy frames moving to various docking areas on the exterior of the station;a pair were angling for the nearby hangar bay .

Rogelio hoped beyond hope that Ke was keeping his head down. Even as he lined up another kill shot on a fleeing ship, he did not envy the chaos about to be unleashed inside the station.

"Get the hell outta here Huntara," Adora growled as she stalked back towards the airlock of the gunship.

"What? No, we have people still out there!"

"And a squadron of Horde fighters, fresh and equipped, with drones being slaved to support. The delaying phase is done."

"I… *dammit,* "growled Huntara as she looked back over her shoulder. Adora paused and looked at her and smiled sadly.

"Seahawk rubbing of f on you. Hardened bounty hunter to hero," she cocked her head, "It' s a good look on you."

Huntara snorted, "Eh, go fight now , flirt later. I owe you for that right hook. Coming in for a close pass. Y. ou sure about this?"

"Nope. But my other option is trying ti while the horde arelanding and I dont have any charges left to cause a ruckus."

"Huh?" Huntara glanced forwards as she angled a flight path close to the base's forward hangar, "I don't get you"…

"Well, I could go in hot, land on the back of a drop ship, blow it, jump off it, kill all the troops in the hangar and then." Adora shrugged and sighed, "Well… I could *try*. But wayyyy too many things could go wrong there. I'm fast, good with a gun but fill the air with enough lead and I do die. I'm violent but not *stupid*."

Huntara cackled, then slowed the craft a little, "Alright, here's your window. Good luck. Get them outta there. Well circle round for the next departure, the rest you gotta get out on your own."

"Good luck to you too," Adora checked the seal on her helmet, then breached the hatch again. The gunship interior had no atmosphere anyway, the crew all in their suits, but it felt weirdly vulnerable with the hatch open. With a push of her legs, she sailed free of the craft, flying out at an angle, the ships momentum transferred to her. She moved diagonally towards the shielded bay, and then triggered her suits thrusters to slow her descent. She angled it so she breached the shield only ten feet above the bay floor, but she was still travelling quite fast. She hit the gravity field and then tumbled, impacting the deck hard. Something cracked in her shoulder and she yelped in pain, rolling across the deck.

Wincing, she stood and let the jury-rigged chest piece dump more painkillers into her system. She could have let the Praetorian enhancements go wild, to try to fix the damage, but she reckoned

that she'd need a *major* infusion of food and it was risky. That she wanted to save for combat, if it was needed.

She looked to the end of the bay and saw the meagre defensive line near the hatch that led to the station interior. The cargo bay doors were sealed, welded shut, but this door, for personnel, was open, in case the shuttles tried to disengage and land. None had thought, fighting to the last it seemed. She hoped some had managed to disengage and flee.

She felt a twinge of pride and a knot of sadness. So many lives lost.

The defenders were holed up behind barricades made from scrapped ship metal and empty barrels. A few more stood on the gantries above, weapons trained. The commander of the team recognised her as she ran towards them, "Commander Adora?"

She grimaced at the title, "Dropships inbound. How's the evac going? Comms are still fried out there."

"Uh..just some civvies who want to stay , holed up on the commerce deck. And uh, the security teams and the command personnel."

"Wait, Angella's still here?" Adora cursed, "We need to get out n-"

She was interrupted by the roar of an engine as a Horde dropship blasted into the bay. The ship was *not* elegant - a boxy troop compartment, fronted by a bulbous cockpit and flanked by stubby wings with rotating engines. Adora's eyes widened and she yanked the commander down as a turret mounted on the vessel's "chin" spooled up and straffed the barricade. A dorsal turret swivelled and began to suppress the soldiers on the gantries. Adora blinked in shock as a rocket streaked from one gantry. It hit the dropship's flank, but only nudged the bulky vessel a little: the things were designed to land in hot LZs: a firecracker of an RPG wouldn't do much more than dent it.

If they aimed for the engines, maybe, but still.

The gantry exploded as one of the turrets raked the railing, hitting some of the ordinance and triggering it. Adora risked a glance over the barricade and cursed.

The dropship had begun to descend, its belly-turret joining the fore turret in suppressing resistance. And then, to add insult to injury, a pair of sphereical bots dropped from alcoves in the stubby wings. They clanged against the decking, then extended their spidery legs and began to advance, firing as they came. The hatches on the side of the ship opened and troops in bulker armour leapt clear, dropping the twenty feet to the deck with heavy thuds.

"Crap, they're using assault armour," Adora cursed, "Fall back, into the corridors."

“W ell cover you. Right behind you.” The commander met her gaze and Adora shivered. No time to argue though.

She turned and sprinted, ducking as blaster fire lanced by her. She turned back and watched as one defender stood to take a shot, only to judder as rounds impacted against them. The commander was trying to rally the defenders, then turned to flee. Cut several of the defenders in half, only the commander and three others making it away from the barricade. Adora punched a panel and the door sealed shut, “W ont hold them long. Get to the evac shuttles.”

The commander shook her head, “No, well fall to the next defence line. Need to buy the rest of you time.”

Adora cursed but, again, didnt argue. She adjusted the rifle on her shoulder and winced at the pain, then turned and dashed towards the command centre.

As she ran, speakers began to blare out a siren, low and rhythmic, along with a warning, “ *Imperial troops have entered the base. I repeat, Imperial troops have entered the base. All personnel to evacuation points.”*

She picked up speed.

Glimmer watched, pensive, as the number of *friendlies* began to drop. As the battle had raged, things had looked positive: the drones had been picked apart and they'd even seemingly damaged two of the frigates. But then their defensive gambits had begun to run out; their fighters began to dwindle, each loss more impactful. They'd gotten most of the station prepped and evacuation had begun. Now they had a good two thirds out, though a couple of fleeing ships had been disabled, it seemed. Now she swallowed as the last fighter winked out. More enemy signatures had appeared: fighters and drop ships. She watched with dread as several began to merge with the outline of the station.

She heard one of the officers make the announcement and swallowed. The command centre was emptier now, Angella having sent many to flee. It was her, Bow, Juliet and a few others, alongside Angella. The Security chief looked to be fretting - her wife, Casta, was shepherding wounded into one of the shuttles in the bay at the far side of the base. Perfuma was helping her, along with DT.

A clatter at the entrance to the room made them turn. Glimmer blinked in shock as Adora panted and staggered inside, "Need.to go. *Now."*

Angella looked over, "Not until everyone is clear ."

"They are using assault troopers and droids. Not just marines. Pull everyone back, collapse corridors, just *get away* . Ill. Ill buy you time, ok?" Adora looked harried and winced. Glimmer frowned.

"You're hurt"…

"Yeah, it's combat. Ill be fine, Glimmer . But I need you all to clear out."

She was interrupted by a faint *krump* noise and the distant sound of weapons fire. It cut out suddenly And Adora shook her head. The others exchanged glances, but it was Juliet who grabbed Angella and began to haul her away, "She' s right, we cant do anything here."

"But what about"…

"No. T ime. Let' s *go."*

Their group headed back into the corridor, the rest of the command staff streaming ahead of them, weapons ready. As they were moving through a junction the lights flickered, then shifted to emergency red. Adora cursed, "They must've breached the generators.or found a way to subvert the systems. Go ahead"…

The group moved forward,s but Glimmer paused as she realised Adora had turned to head back, "Adora wa-"she was cut of f as a hatch descended and clanged shut, then clanked again as locks engaged. Through the small, glass viewport, Angella stared back, alongside Bow and the others. Adora turned and blinked in shock.

"A w crap."

Her plan to engage the enemy was *out* . Now she needed to get Glimmer clear.

It was strange - before now, that would have been a weirdly alien thought: she'd have left Glimmer and gone to fight, rationalising that killing the enemy meant saving the civilian. But now, now she didn't *want* to leave Glimmer alone. She looked at the others and yelled, "W ell find another way!Get clear!"

Bow nodded, his face resolute. They dragged Angella away who seemed to be yelling something. Adora turned to Glimmer, who looked back at her with nervous resolve, "Ok Adora.uhm.what do we do?"

"W e.survive."

—

Catra watched the tablet in her hands as it streamed the gun-cam footage from the first dropship. She watched a blurry image as defenders tried to retreat. Robots advanced, cover exploded. She smiled grimly as, when the door sealed, the assault troopers stacked up alongside the door and breached it, moving into the corridor with precision and suppressing fire. Behind them, the robots formed up, then extended portable barriers in front of them for the regular marines to advance behind.

Base clearing was slow, arduous. Yes you could breach and clear fast;or your could be methodical. And seeing as there was a Praetorian aboard, Catra felt it best to go slow and steady and have a lot of forward facing firepower.

She flicked the view to another breach, this time the helmet cam of one of the airlock teams. They were advancing carefully, taking fire from around corners. Flashbang grenades flared and the troops followed up. Screams and tinny sounds of gunfire came from the speakers, but she muted it.

Catra looked up as the dropship coasted into the seized hanger . It settled down and she turned to watch her contingent of troops debark. They moved quickly , professionally: yes the bay was theirs, but this wasnt friendly territory . She moved into the troop bay, then reached up to snag the case.

She followed the soldiers as they advanced into the base: the bay was secured, with troops moving to secure the gantries and police the bodies. Inside the corridor, it was a mess: bodies lay slumped against the walls;all Rebels. She tried to ignore the form of a young

woman, the wall around her pock marked with burn marks from blaster fire. The woman had no body armour, just ragged coveralls and an ill fitting helmet.

Catra walked past, her jaw tight.

Ahead she could hear intermittent gunfire. Around herher escort moved carefully, cautiously, even though the main breaching team were ahead. One of the men, a Sergeant, raised a tablet of his own and tapped at it, then looked to Catra, "One the teams has patcheed into the station network. We've got mapping. Teams four and five are moving to the generators. The other hangar bay it on the other side of the station: we're going to have to cut through some narrow choke points, maybe the concourse."

Catra nodded, "Dont over extend or split the forces. The Praetorian will take advantage of that. She knows this area better than we do. She *will* take advantage."

"Yes ma'am," the soldier keyed his comm and began giving orders. Catra checked her tablet and looked through the map data. She was interrupted as the Sergeant looked back at her, "We have contact: an armoury, enemy forces holed up it looks like. Resistance at the generators too. And we have identified a contingent of civilians on the concourse..and..a Horde soldier"?

Catra frowned, then keyed up the channel for the concourse team, which brought up a small viewer. The team lead nodded to her over the channel, "*Ma'am. We have several surrendering civilians. They*

had marked out an area. One was wounded as we weren't sure, but one of them identified as a prisoner of war. We have secured them, no resistance."

"We'll Secure that man for interrogation," Catra hissed. The team lead looked confused for a moment, then nodded.

" *And the rest of them?"*

"Keep them corralled for now . We will process and assess once the station is secure. Ensure no weaponry, no communication systems or anything like that is active in that area. Secure entrances, seal it off. Clear?"

" *Yes ma'am."*

Catra nodded, then cocked her head as another channel flared up. Panicked voices reporting they'd been flanked. She cut to that channel only to see men firing blindly down a corridor. Something darted from cover and fired twice. Two soldiers went down, their helmet visors bloodied. Catra swore and keyed in the channel, "Fall back to the Assault position, this is your *Captain* . Fall. Back."

The soldiers seemed to hear her, and the volume of fire down the corridor increased as they began to retreat.

Catra hissed out a breath, then noted the position - a corridor junction near what looked like a command centre and an accessway . She noted that the techies who'd suborned the systems had clearly deactivated power, at least in some parts of the station;and sealed hatches in other areas, seemingly at random. She smiled at that: good initiative.

But that meant there were only a couple of pathways to that other hangar. In fact.there were no open avenues. She cocked her head and smiled thinly.

"Only one option, Adora."

It wasnt going well. The boarders had sealed of f all access to the hangar, clearly cutting off one side of the station from the other. In addition, this place ahd little room to manoeuvre;and she had to account for Glimmer. The *sensible* thing would be to abandon the woman, get into the maintenance access ways and then ambush as best she could . Except she wasnt operating at *peak* , she was hurting, had limited weaponry *and* a civilian to look after.

They'd encountered one advanced group of Marines and she'd had to tap into some of her Praetorian reflexes;that had hurt a lot as the nanites kicked in, having been forced to temporary dormancy. She'd managed to double back, hide Glimmer behind another junction, then managed to use an engineering alcove to get a flanking action

against the cautious soldiers. Four of them she'd downed, but she'd had to pull back as her rifle had clicked on *empty* . The Marines had pulled back, hauling their casualties and their weapons with them, so Adora was stuck.

Now, she crouched with Glimmer checking the map of the station - it wasn't *huge* huge, but big enough that the enemy was having to be cautious. That gave them time - maybe more minutes, rather than hours, though. Adora sighed and shook her head, "I can't breach the hatches, we can't get through the maintenance ducts as *they're* sealed too, can't get to the generator as it's being assaulted and this place doesn't have *escape pods* . Not that those would do us much good - just get us picked up."

"Didn't you, like, fight a guerilla resistance against these guys in a *ruin* ?" Glimmer frowned, "That's what you said."

"A ruin where I had resources, charges, weaponry and terrain advantage," Adora sighed and leaned against the corridor wall, "And they still got me. I could've maybe killed *more* of them but... No easy way to get out, if you don't know how many *more* enemies there are. Praetorians are deadly... but not invincible. If I... go feral, yeah I'll be able to tear them up more, but ferals still get put down."

"So, what, we're giving up?" Glimmer looked horrified. Adora snorted.

"No... we just have to... do something *really* stupid," she tapped the map. Glimmer arched an eyebrow, then her other one rose.

"You can't be serious! You just said we CAN'T take them!"

"Don't need to. We just need to get *past* them. Closest ship is *here*. We can't get to the ones in the main bay - too many guards. But the airlocked ships? Better chances."

Adora checked her side arm - that still had some charges left. Just not great for a sustained firefight. She looked at Glimmer and shrugged. The other woman rolled her eyes, "We are so going to die...".

The plan was straightforward - evade and circumvent. The enemy expected resistance, maybe the odd person waiting in ambush. But they didn't expect people to literally hide under deck plating as they passed. Which was how the pair of them managed to get *behind* an advancing squad of Marines and then made their way to one of the auxiliary airlocks.

Adora was cautious, and checked every turn, every junction. The dim red lighting made every movement slow; a flash or a twitch of shadows had them freezing up. But it seemed the majority of the boarders were advancing down to the generators or attempting to break through to the hangar bay. In here they couldn't risk using comms or the intercom system, so Adora had no idea if the enemy were capturing more people or if the rest had escaped.

After managing to avoid another set of troops who were doubling back to check before advancing again, Adora and Glimmer found themselves at the airlock. A pair of Marines stood guard. Adora peered around the corner and grimaced. She checked her belt and unhooked one of the stun batons she'd salvaged from the frigate armoury. She fiddled with it, then nodded and threw it around the corner. There was a cry of surprise, followed by a sudden blast and juddering groans. When the pair moved around the corner they found the Marines slump, unconscious, smoke rising from them. Glimmer arched an eyebrow at Adora who shrugged, "Horde tech is either super good orrrr..super unreliable."

Adora disarmed the pair of troops, then swiftly moved to tied their hands using the straps from their rifles. Then, carefully, she peered inside the dropship hatch. She ducked back and pressed a finger to her lips, then crept aboard. Glimmer waited until she heard a series of thuds followed by yelps and the crack of a pistol. Adora emerged a moment later, dragging an unconscious pilot, before disappearing and coming back a second, then a third time. She grimaced as she then moved to apply a tourniquet to one of the unconscious pilots. Glimmer frowned at her.

"You..didn't kill them?"

Adora paused and cocked her head. She then looked up at Glimmer in surprise, "Huh..no..I..uh..I..didn't?"

"But you *did* kill the ones in the corridor?" she gestured back, to where the skirmish had happened. Adora winced.

"That was...instinctive. This way I...I chose."

Glimmer bit her lip, then moved to enter the dropship. She froze as a voice cut through the air, "Well, isn't this cute."

Adora shot up, hand on her sidearm in an instant. Glimmer turned and saw a feline woman in a Horde Captain's uniform. The woman had a strange case in one hand, her hips cocked and her free hand planted on a hip. Her Captains hat sat at a jaunty angle. Glimmer blinked in shock, "Wait, that's...her?"

The blonde stared at Catra, eyes darting about, watching for an ambush. But Catra seemed alone, "What...what...is?"..

"Hey , Adora," Catra smirked, but her features seemed tense, "Had a feeling I'd find you here."

Adora stared at the woman. They'd last traded barbs through an energy field, separated by that and time and *some much more* . Her hand trembled, the chest rig going into overdrive as her emotions bubbled and *something* in her tried to react to the increase in stress.

Catra's tail swished from side to side. Her eyes narrowed at Glimmer, then dismissed her. SHe looked down at the unconscious soldiers and sighed, "Well, that's a surprise. I thought you promised me blood Adora"...

Her voice wasn't mocking, more curious. Adora swallowed, "I can do that"…

Catra tensed then held up her hand, "No! No. I… I think we've had enough. I know you could do a lot more but." Catra took a deep breath, then set the case down on the floor. Adora's eyes locked onto it, then widened in shock, "I got… given this. I think you need it."

Adora's gaze flicked back to Catra, then her eyes narrowed, "Why?"

Catra's jaw set, "Because, *idiot*, I tried to SAVE you. And you KILLED everyone. I want you *gone*. GONE. Away." The feline woman's fists balled and her tailed whipped back and forth. She glared and then looked away, "You spared us. I tried to spare you. And I know a fight will go *badly*. Hell, you could just finish this now."

She turned her gaze back and tilted her chin up. Adora stared at her, her hand still hovering over her side arm. Then she deflated and her hand dropped. The blonde sighed and she let out a hollow laugh, "I… couldn't."

"I know," Catra whispered, her voice quiet. She swallowed and tried to look stoic, "I know. And you're an *idiot* for it. So… so I *know* I owe you, ok? I owe you so much. And it *kills me*. So… so just take the loss, Adora. Take the loss here and *go*. Get away. Be *free*, ok?" She put her foot on the case… in pushed it, sliding it across the deck a little. Adora moved forwards, cautiously, then lifted the black case. She looked suddenly confused, lost. This wasn't how this was supposed

to happen. She was going to put Glimmer on the drop ship, set a course, then come back in here and…

And what? Fight until she died? Killed all the Horde.

"The civilians still"…

"I'm not a monster Adora, despite what you may think. I will…make sure they're treated fairly . Me though,"she shook her head, "I know something happened. That…that' s on *you* ."Adora flinched at that.

"I cant let you hurt"…

"T ake. The. oss, Adora,"Catra growled. Then she let out a sigh, "The other ships *will* be able to leave. In fact, i think they already *have* . My ships wont pursue. No point. W e have what we came for."

Adora nodded jerkily , then backed away. Glimmer watched, confused and Adora turned to her, "Get in the ship. Strap in,"she turned back to Catra, then looked down at the case then back up. "Come with us."

Catra startled at that and frowned, "What"?

"Leave the Horde. Come with us. Y ou know it…it' s not"…

Catra let out a bitter laugh, "And what? Float around in a dead system? Adora I... I know I did some... but you left me and I have a *future* now." her fists clenched again and he glared at the blonde, as she yammered, "I made my choice. I have to... to look after *my* people as well."

Adora's jaw twitched and she let out a sad laugh, "Just.. not... huh." She nodded slowly, then turned away.

"Adora, wait." the blonde turned and Catra dashed towards her . The blonde flinched, ready for a strike. But Catra drew up short and gripped Adora's shirt. She yanked the blonde down and pressed a kiss to her lips. It was hard, and lasted only a moment. Then she released Adora and pressed their foreheads together, "Please just… just *go* . Be free. Please."

The blonde choked and exhaled, then stumbled back. Her eyes were wet, confused. Catra sniffled, but straightened up. Adora nodded curtly, then boarded the ship. The airlock hissed shut and the blonde stumbled to the cockpit. Glimmer was strapped into the co-pilot's chair and frowned at Adora, "What"…

"No time. Gotta go."

With a few practiced flicks, the ship disengaged from the station. Around them, the starscape whirled as Adora oriented the ship. The space seemed clear, the patrolling fighters not noting their

movement as anomalous: no alarm had been triggered after all. She checked the sensors: only a couple of disabled freighters;the hangar bay appeared clear - more Horde drop ships seemed to be moving in, indicating that the rest of the station was free. But they wouldnt know for sure until later.

And there wasnt anything Adora could do *out here*. For a moment she considered opening the case, donning what was inside and *ending* things. It would be bloody, it would be violent and...

...and likely wouldnt actually *end* anything. Adora slumped and shook her head, suddenly very very tired. Theyd done what theyd needed to do, saved who they could. A win in some ways. A loss in so many others. Next to her she could hear Glimmer fidgeting. That drew her focus back. She still had a job to do.

Adora keyed in a set of co-ordinates and inhaled. A moment later, the dropship went full burn, then jumped away .

—

Catra stared at the sealed airlock and willed herself to stop shaking. She felt the tears begin to streak down her face. Roughly, she wiped them away,growling as she did so. Part of her felt shed made the wrong choice in that moment. What the choice was, she wasnt sure. But maybe this time, she had saved Adora. Maybe. Not that it mattered. She had all she needed, her debt paid *again*. Or part of it. SHe hoped Adora would listen this time, stay *away*.

With a hiss, she keyed her comm, "We have a dropship hijacked. Report to captured airlock C-3, crewmembers down. Medical team to my location!"

Catra disengaged the command and sighed, then rolled her shoulders.

She had her duty to attend to, after all.

Chapter End Notes

> And so ends another thrilling escapade of SPACE CAPTAIN CATRAAAA!
>
> Stay tuned for another exiting episode!

End Notes

I don't think this one will be TOO long, but I wanted to start showing how Adora became what she is.

ALSO - A GREAT MANY THANKS to Emily Doodles who has provide that cover image for the work! She's on Ko-Fi and takes commissions under: emileedoodles

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!